

CM Rekha launches heritage clubs in 75 Government schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday launched Heritage Clubs in 75 CM Shri Government Schools, aimed at directly connecting students with Delhi's historical, cultural, architectural and documentary heritage through practical, student-centric activities.

The Heritage Clubs will be run jointly by the Department of Art, Culture and Language and the Delhi Archives. The Chief Minister said every activity in a school, every initiative and every page of a book matters for a child's future, and the clubs would serve as a means of linking students directly with the city's rich heritage.

Education Minister Ashish Sood, Art, Culture and Language Minister Kapil Mishra, Department Secretary K Mahesh, Director of Education Ankita Anand, and a large number of teachers and principals from CM Shri



Schools attended the launch.

The Chief Minister said ensuring education, safety and a better environment for children was a shared responsibility. She said Delhi carries a rich history, home to significant aspects of different historical periods, cultural traditions, religious sites, monuments and architectural heritage, and that the Heritage Clubs would let students go beyond textbooks to see, understand and experi-

ence this heritage first-hand.

The Chief Minister said several chapters of history had not yet adequately reached children, and the clubs would give students an opportunity to learn about, understand and reflect on these chapters.

She said the country should move forward with a strong understanding of its heritage and identity, and that the clubs, though a small step, could build a sense of respon-

sibility among children toward knowing and preserving their heritage.

The Chief Minister said children should be empowered to understand their circumstances, face challenges, find solutions and move forward sensibly, and that addressing gaps in infrastructure, teacher facilities and the overall school environment required collective effort from the Chief Minister, ministers, officers, teachers and school heads alike.

Sood said the Government was giving special priority to art, culture, education and Delhi's heritage, with a key objective of establishing Delhi as the country's startup and cultural capital alongside its political capital.

Mishra said Delhi's history extends beyond Mehrauli and the Red Fort, and the Heritage Clubs would introduce students to the city's fuller history and culture, in line with Modi's vision of "Development as well as Heritage."

PWD to repair 600 km roads by December

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh has said the road repair works have once again started and the Government plans to repair 600 kilometres of roads by December this year.

In the past few months, the road repair projects had stopped after the West Asia war affected the supply and pushed up the prices of bitumen, a petroleum byproduct used in road construction. But recently, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) approved cost escalation proposals for all the projects starting from April this year to November.

"Due to the war situation, the supply of bitumen was affected, and its prices also saw a significant increase. This led to delays in the work, but we have reissued the tender and restarted the work afresh," Singh said late Thursday night.

"Road construction and the resurfacing work is not feasible in winter, so a target has been set to complete



600 kilometres of roads by December, and work is progressing rapidly on the identified roads," he added.

The minister also said that the roads should not only be built quickly but also be durable, and for this purpose, he informed that a team from Netaji Subhas University of Technology is monitoring the quality through third-party audits.

"Additionally, the company awarded the road construction contract will also be responsible for main-

taining the road for the next five years," he added.

The road repair work is not taken up during monsoon, and in winters, with night temperatures dropping below 15 degrees Celsius, the bitumen laying becomes difficult, an official said.

Last year, the central Government approved a fund request of Rs 803 crore for 152 road-related projects across Delhi covered under the Central Road and Infrastructure Fund. Separately, the Delhi

Government has also taken up other road repair works.

PWD currently manages a road network of approximately 1,400 km across Delhi, which is being taken up for improvement in a phased manner. Out of this, tenders for work on 400 km have been floated that will be covered under the cost-escalation proposal. Additionally, 200 km of roads which are being funded by the Delhi Government will also be included in the overall repair works.

DDA holds sixth, seventh MPD 2047 consultations with architects and planners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority held its sixth and seventh rounds of stakeholder consultations on the Master Plan for Delhi 2047 with architects, planners and other professional stakeholders on Friday.

The consultation focused on spatial development policies including Transit Oriented Development, Land Pooling Areas, High Density Corridors and Low Density Areas.

The consultations, held in line with directions from Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, aimed to foster wider stakeholder understanding and facilitate effective, participatory implementation of the Master Plan.

The sixth consultation was attended by architects, planners and representatives of NBCC, the Council of Architecture, the School of Planning and Architecture, the Institute of Town Planners India, the Delhi Jal Board and the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board. The



seventh consultation was attended by DEs, architects and planners. During the consultations, DDA provided an overview of MPD 2047 and its vision of creating a sustainable, green and liveable national capital.

Stakeholders were briefed on various Spatial Development Policies under the Master Plan, including Transit Oriented Development, Land Pooling Areas, High Density Corridors and Low Density Areas. Detailed information was shared on the Land Pooling Policy, covering DDA's proactive role in the development process, the specific mechanism for land

assembly, and the development of new road networks and other planned infrastructure in Land Pooling Areas.

The Transit Oriented Development framework was discussed, including Residential Affordable Housing Zones. Stakeholders were briefed on High Density Corridor development along both sides of Urban Extension Road-II.

The consultations also covered policy provisions relating to Low Density Areas and redevelopment in planned areas, spanning residential, commercial and industrial zones. Stakeholders were apprised of planning provisions for the O-Zone, particularly those relating to the rejuvenation of the River Yamuna and its floodplains.

Heritage conservation was discussed, covering the preservation and improvement of heritage buildings and sites. The Comprehensive Mobility Plan and provisions relating to Transferable Development Rights were covered as part of the broader planning framework under MPD 2047.

4.74 crore children out of school, experts seek alternate learning paths

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An estimated 4.74 crore children in India remain outside the school system, experts said at a consultation organised by Prayas Juvenile Aid Centre (JAC) Society and India Habitat Centre (IHC) on September 14, calling for stronger alternative and flexible education pathways to reach them.

The consultation, titled "Alternative and Innovative Education for Out of School Children (OOSC) and Socio Economically Disadvantaged Groups (SEDGs): The Role of CSOs," was held at Casurina, IHC, bringing together education-ists, Government representatives and civil society organisations to discuss educational exclusion and learner-centred pathways for children outside formal schooling.

Moderating the discussion, Amod K Kanth, Founder and Mentor of Prayas JAC Society and Former DGP (IPS), cited the NSSO's 75th Round household survey (2017-18), which found



3.22 crore children aged 6 to 17 out of school, alongside an estimated 4.74 crore children in the same age group outside the school system. He noted UDISE+ 2024-25 data showing India has 14.71 lakh schools and 24.69 crore students. Kanth also referenced NITI Aayog's report "Reimagining Skilling for Viksit Bharat@2047," which estimates 8.7 crore youth aged 15 to 29 are NEET, not in education, employment or training.

Rita Panicker Pinto, Executive Director of Butterflies, shared field experience from Uttarakhand on identifying out-

of-school children through collaboration between the Education Department, district administration and CSOs, describing civil society organisations as vital last-mile partners bridging children back into formal schooling, open schooling and skills training.

Prof (Dr) Kamalakat Biswal of NIEPA, Ministry of Education, raised concerns over limitations in existing education data and called for better household-level data, locally relevant approaches, improved teacher quality and attention to social and economic circumstances

affecting children's readiness to learn.

Dr Sujeet Ranjan, CEO of United Way of Delhi, emphasised a life cycle approach from enrolment through learning, retention and transition to skills and livelihoods, highlighting the role of CSOs in connecting children, parents, schools, Government and CSR partners, alongside early engagement through Anganwadi centres.

India Habitat Centre Director K G Suresh said strengthening education foundations at the primary and school level was essential, noting that unemployment, remains among the biggest challenges, and called for stronger Government-CSO partnerships and actionable policies.

In his concluding remarks, Prof Binay Pattanayak, Member, NCERT, and Chief Consultant, NSTC Programme Office, NCERT, said bringing children into school must be accompanied by attention to education quality, underlining the role of School Management Committees, Panchayati Raj institutions, NIOS and CSOs.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Invitation of Tenders through E-procurement system

Principal chief materials manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001 for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for the following items:

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing time
01	82265020	AFA & Er - Yag aser Specification as per PDF attached	01 No	16.10.2026

Note:- 1. Bidders may visit the IREPS website: www.ireps.gov.in for details.
2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 82265020 Date: 18.09.2026
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PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mr. Munidev (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagee/Borrowers), is purchasing Plot Bearing No. C-33, carved out of Khasra No. 713, Mohalla Agna Ghar Colony (Sahjan Samiti Ltd.) measuring 209 Sq. Mtrs., Changan, Harpal, U.P. from Mr. Vinay Kumar who became the owner of the said property by virtue of Sale Deed dated 11.11.2019, regd. as Doc. No. 7152, in Advt. Book No. 1, Vol. No. 11303 on pages 1-10, 11, 12019, with the Vile dated 21.10.2016, regd. as Doc. No. 793, Book No.3, Volume No. 463, Page No. 77-86, registered on 21.10.2016 (SR 1 Mensu). The Borrower will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Axis Bank Ltd., Aditya City Center, Plot No. CGH-3, Vaidhyanand Khand, 1st Indraprastha, Ghaziabad. Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary disposition or otherwise or having in their custody any title document pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claims of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 07 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client.
Adv. Simran Bajaj, 100, 1st Floor, Okhla Phase-III, New Delhi-110020, Phone: +91 1148714545/99

PUBLIC NOTICE

Shri Kamleshwar Prasad Khanwal, son of Late Sadanand Khanwal, resident of Village Pasta Malia, Tehsil Salpuli, Block Jaiharikhal, District Pauri Garhwal, Uttarakhand, husband of Smt. Manorama Khanwal and father of Shri Mayank Khanwal, has been missing since 2002. No information till date. Anyone having knowledge may contact Mayank Khanwal, C/7288 A Keshav Pura New Delhi 110035, Mob: 9999419333. Otherwise, he shall be presumed dead

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public at large that Mrs. Ranjana Kumari W/o Mr. Mahesh Kumar intends to purchase the Residential Vacant Plot No. 30-A, measuring 34.69 Sq. Yds. (29 Sq. Mtrs.), out of Khasra No. 279, situated at Om Sai Garden, Gail No. 3 (Railway Line ke Paar), Village Chitpaya Bujurg, Pargana & Tehsil Dadri, District Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh. The purchaser further intends to develop the aforesaid property with Niwas Housing Finance Limited, Boundaries: East: Plot of Chanchal, West: Rasta 18 Ft. wide, North: Plot No. 29, Shri Sam & South: Rasta 20 Feet Wide. It is further brought to the notice of the general public that certain documents relating to the title/ownership of the said property are not available with the Seller, namely: 1. Original Sale Deed dated 04.03.2014 (Doc. No. A4522 And 2). Original Correction Deed pertaining to Sale Deed dated 04.03.2014 is not available with Seller. Any person having any claim or objection must notify the undersigned in writing within 7 days, failing which it will be presumed there are no objections.

NCR LAW ASSOCIATES, Advocate & Consultants, A-99, Sector-09, New Vihar, Gurgaon, Haryana, U.P-201009, Mob. Nos. 9999711152/ 9999826427

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I, Ruma Ray, W/o
No.15796162Y Hav (DS)
Chandan Kumar, R/o- Vill-
Puranigadiya, PO- Chato, P.S-
Devari, Jharkhand - 815314,
have changed my name from
Ruma Ray to Ruma Kumari,
vide affidavit dated
18/09/2026 before Notary
Public Delhi.

I, G Nagamma, Mother of
No.15779631A BHM (GNR)
Kasi Rao Guvvala, R/o- PO-
Bollupalli, Md- Ardhaveedu
Dist- Prakasam, Andhra
Pradesh- 523335, have
changed my name from G
Nagamma to Guvvala
Nagamma, vide affidavit
dated 18/09/2026 before
Notary Public Delhi.

I, Bishna Sengar, Mother
of No.16014348H Hav
Sandeep Singh Sengar, R/o-
Vill- Shekhpur Bujurg, Dist-
Jalaun, U.P- 285128, have
changed my name from
Bishna Sengar to Vishuna
Devi, vide affidavit dated
18/09/2026 before Notary
Public Delhi.

I, Parsuram Panigrahi,
Father of No.4291286N
Sep Dibya Ranjan Panigrahi,
R/o- Vill- Kasamilla, PO-
Haripur, Dist- Baleshwar,
Odisha- 756003, have
changed my name from
Parsuram Panigrahi to
Parshuram Panigrahi, vide
affidavit dated 17/09/2026
before Notary Public Delhi.

I, No.14866761H NK/MT
Sajan Lama Tamang, R/o-
Special Forest Busty, PO-
Fagu, Dist- Darjeeling, West
Bengal- 735231, have
changed my Mother's name
in my Army Service Record
from Fulo Lama Tamang to
Fulo Lama Tamang, vide affidavit
dated 18/09/2026 before
Notary Public Delhi.

I, Tushar Bhadouria S/o
Raj Naresh Bhadouria R/o B-
47, Krishan Vihar, Delhi-
110086. In my CBSE records
my father's name is written as
Raj Naresh Bhadouria. But my
father's actual & correct name
is Raj Naresh Singh. Raj
Naresh Singh & Raj Naresh
Bhadouria both are same &
one person.

I, Tushar Bhadouria S/o
Raj Naresh Bhadouria R/o B-
47, Krishan Vihar, Delhi-
110086. In my CBSE records
my mother's name is written as
Pratiba. But my mother's
correct name is Neeraj Singh.
Neeraj Singh & Pratiba both
are the same and one person.

I, Guddi, W/o Satish
Chandra R/o B-76, Natwar
Nagar, Dhauri Pyaw, Mathura,
Uttar Pradesh-281001 have
changed my name to Aruna
Chaudhary.

ADVERTORIAL

Team Anantam: From the Classroom to the World Stage

Team Anantam, a student-led STEM Racing team from Genesis Global School, Noida, is taking its passion for engineering, design and innovation to the world stage. What began as a miniature race-car competition has evolved into a journey of teamwork, leadership, sustainability and problem-solving. The team brings together diverse skills in design, manufacturing, finance, content and graphic design to develop, build and present its car while overcoming challenges. Beyond racing, Anantam promotes environmental awareness through plant drives

and sustainability initiatives. It also introduces younger students to STEM through engaging engineering and problem-solving activities. With Genesis Global School's support, the team has gained opportunities to experiment, innovate and develop practical skills beyond the classroom. Following national-level success, Team Anantam will represent India at the STEM Racing World Finals 2026 in Singapore. With the spirit of "Fast. Fierce. Fearless.", the team is ready to showcase Indian talent, innovation and determination on the international stage.

PUBLIC NOTICE

The General Public is hereby informed that our client, Emaar India Limited and its subsidiaries had entered into a transaction with Worldwide Resorts And Entertainment Private Limited ("WREPL") for the joint development of a project on the Scheduled Land. The General Public is further informed that any prior termination, revocation and cancellation of the said transaction (including termination letter dated 04 July 2025) has been withdrawn, rescinded and/or reversed, and the grant of rights to WREPL under the transaction documents continue to remain valid, subsisting, binding and in full force and effect, subject to compliance with the terms of the transaction documents. The public at large is hereby informed that WREPL is duly entitled to exercise, enjoy, avail and act upon its development rights in relation to the Scheduled Land strictly in accordance with the terms of the transaction documents. This Notice is issued in the public interest by Emaar India Limited and its subsidiaries owning the Scheduled Land.

Schedule Land referred to hereinabove
I. Description of property measuring 73.60 acres in Sub-tehsil Manesar, District Gurugram, Haryana, as described below:
II. Parties to the transaction:
1. Emaar India Limited (CIN: U45201DL2005PLC131151), having its registered office at 306-308, Square One, C-2, District Centre, Saket, New Delhi-110017, and its subsidiaries.
2. Worldwide Resorts And Entertainment Pvt. Ltd. (CIN: U74999DL2018PTC291184), having its registered office at House No. 738, 2nd Floor, Block A, Shashi Nagar, North West Delhi, Delhi-110052.
III. Transaction documents:
1. Joint Development Agreement dated 28.06.2023.
2. Addendum dated 04.10.2023.
3. Special Power of Attorney dated 28.06.2023.
Issued by: For and on behalf of Emaar India Limited and the Landowners through their Advocates
Avnish Sharma, Advocate
Khaltan & Co LLP, 8th Floor Max Towers, Sector 16B,
Noida Gautam Buddha Nagar, UP-201301
T: +91 120 479 1000; F: +91 120 474 2000
E: delhi.publicnotice@khaltan.co

PUBLIC NOTICE

In the instruction of our clients Sh. Kamal Kishore aged 60yrs S/o Sh. Genda Ram and Smt. Bimlesh aged 56 yrs W/o Sh. Kamal Kishore both R/o B-85A, Bindapur Pratap Garden, New Delhi-110059 do hereby disown their married son Kuldeep aged 35yrs and his wife Poonam aged 32yrs, their two children Sankhik aged 6yrs Siddhant aged 12yrs all R/o same as above mentioned address from all their moveable and immovable properties and social boycott them, due to their misconduct and wrong doings. Henceforth my clients and their family members shall not be responsible for their any acts. Anybody dealing with them will do at their own cost and risk in future.

In the Court of Senior Civil Judge, "B" Mapusa- Goa
Civil Misc. Application No. 70/2026/B
In the matter of inheritance of late 1. Brji Pal Singh @ B.P. Singh @ Brjpal Singh @ Brji Pal Singh Bawa son of Avtar Singh Bawa aged 67 years, at the time of death was residing at M-88 First Floor, Greater Kailash-2, South Delhi, India 110048.
2. Prakash Bawa @ Prakash Bawa. W/o Brji Pal Singh @ B. P. Singh, @ Brjpal Singh @ Brji Pal Singh Bawa. Age 75 years at the time of death, was residing at, M-88 First Floor, Greater Kailash-2, South Delhi, India 110048.Deceased
1. Mr. Karan Pal Singh @ Karan Pal Singh Bawa, Son of Late Brji Pal Singh @ Brji Pal Singh Bawa and Late Prakash Bawa @ Prakash Bawa, 42 years of age, Business, Indian National,
2. Mrs. Tahira Bawa, Wife of Mr. Karan Pal Singh Bawa, @ Karan Pal Singh Bawa, Holding Aadhar Card No. 2833 6792 6257 Aged 36 years, married, Housewife, Indian National, Both resident of M-88 First Floor, Greater Kailash-2, South Delhi, India 110048.Applicants
NOTICE
WHEREAS the above named applicant have filed an Application under Sec 370 and 372 of Indian Succession Act, on and perusing the said applications this Court has Ordered to issue notice by way of publication on the local daily newspaper calling for objection if any.
AND WHEREAS, the said applicant has stated that there are no more heirs and he/she left neither ascendants nor descendants. THEREFORE, if any person who has a better right or equal right as that of the applicant can put forth his/her claim within 20 days from the publishing of notice.
Take note that if you fail to comply with the above mentioned clause the proceedings shall proceed in your absence.
The matter is fixed for appearance on 21/10/2026 at 10.00 a.m.
Given Under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 24th day of August 2026.
(Ms. Puja U. S. Sardesai)
Senior Civil Judge 'B' Court, Mapusa Mapusa-Goa



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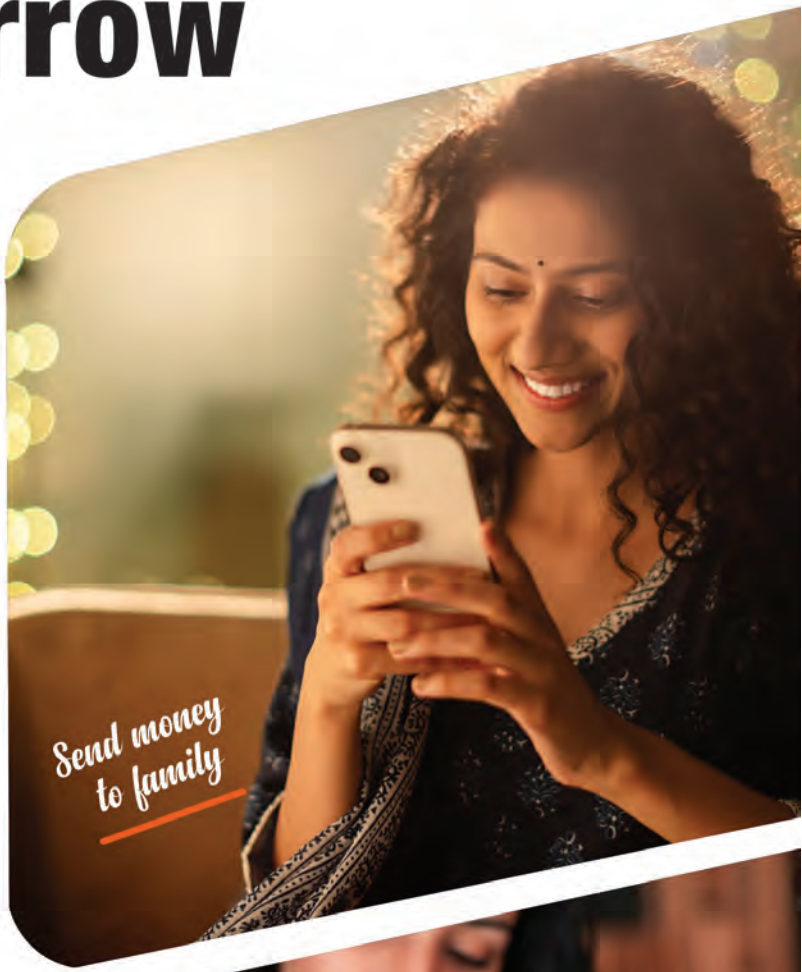


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ABVP sweeps SRCC, college polls; vote counting underway

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) on Friday registered a clean sweep at Shri Ram College of Commerce (SRCC), winning the president and secretary posts along with both councillor seats, as the RSS-affiliated student organisation won in several college union polls across Delhi University even as voting for the central DUSU panel continued.

According to updates shared by student organisations, ABVP candidates secured all four contested positions at SRCC, one of DU's most prominent commerce colleges, by a large margin. The victory at SRCC was part of a broader sweep by ABVP, which also won all posts at Aditi Mahavidyalaya and Bharti College, and secured key positions at several other campuses.

The ABVP panel recorded a 6-0 clean sweep at Sri Aurobindo College (Morning), won all 8 posts at Bharati College, and registered a 6-0 clean sweep at Shivaji College. At Dr Bhim Rao Ambedkar College, ABVP won all four posts.

At Keshav Mahavidyalaya, ABVP candidates won the three key posts of President, Vice President and Secretary by substantial margins. At Shyama Prasad Mukherjee College, ABVP candidates won the posts of President and Secretary along with both Central Councillor posts. At the Department of Library Sciences, ABVP candidates also won the posts of President and Minister along with both Central Councillor posts.

In a notable outcome, the Students' Federation of India (SFI) won the president's post at Bhaskaracharya College. Archi, a member of SFI's Delhi state committee, was elected president of the college's student union, marking a significant gain for the Left-backed outfit amid a largely ABVP-dominated trend in the college-level results.

The college union results began to be declared even as

voting for the four central Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) posts, namely president, vice-president, secretary and joint secretary, was underway across the university.

Delhi University campuses wore a festive look as candidates and their supporters made a final push to win over students. They distributed pamphlets and displayed placards, urging their peers to vote for their candidates in the ongoing Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections for four central panel positions and college representatives.

The DUSU election witnessed a closely-watched contest among the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), the Congress-affiliated National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and the AISASFI alliance for the four central panel posts — president, vice-president, secretary and joint secretary.

The ABVP alleged that an NSUI worker was caught distributing an incorrect ABVP panel number shortly before voting, while NSUI national president Vinod Jakhar alleged that a former national secretary of the organisation was detained by police

without any reason during the student union election.

Security was tightened across Delhi University on Friday as polling for the DU Students' Union (DUSU) elections got underway, with more than 2,000 police and paramilitary personnel deployed across the North and South campuses. Police have erected barricades outside colleges and were frisking students to avoid any untoward incident. A senior police officer said security arrangements had been put in place around all colleges and other important locations to ensure peaceful polling and maintain law and order.

Police personnel have been deployed at strategic locations, while foot patrols, motorcycle teams and PCR vans are maintaining a visible presence around the campuses, he said. Paramilitary personnel have also been deployed at strategic locations as part of the multi-layered security arrangements.

Counting of votes for the DUSU central panel is scheduled for Saturday at the Multipurpose Hall of the University Sports Stadium in North Campus.



HC flags Lyngdoh violations in student elections, proposes damages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections on Friday saw campaign activities that appeared to violate several rules governing student polls, with printed pamphlets scattered around North Campus, vehicle rallies and the distribution of campaign materials around South Campus.

Around North Campus, printed pamphlets bearing candidates' names were scattered on roads and footpaths. People travelling in vehicles threw pamphlets, particularly around Chhatra Marg and near colleges such as Kirori Mal and Hansraj, while students on motorcycles distributed candidate cards as they moved between colleges.

In South Campus, SUVs and other vehicles moved around university roads as students campaigned for candidates.

The campaigning and the run-up to the election have come under the spotlight again as the Delhi High Court on Friday took note of repeated violations of the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations during the DUSU elections and

proposed imposing collective electoral damages on students and student organisations found violating the norms.

"Having noted frequent violations on the part of the students, candidates and student organisations, we propose to impose collective damages not only on the students found violating the norms but also the student organisations," the bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said.

The court also barred victory processions after the declaration of results and warned of further action for violations. The Lyngdoh Committee recommendations prohibit candidates from using printed posters, pamphlets or other printed materials for canvassing and allow only handmade posters at designated places. They also restrict processions and public meetings outside campuses and prohibit candidates and their supporters from defacing university property.

Delhi University separately put in place a paperless campaign framework for the 2026 polls, barring printed posters, banners and other campaign material on campus and in its



vicinity. Students said almost all major political party-backed candidates violated the Rs 5,000 expenditure limit.

The High Court was told on Friday that challans were issued during the election period, and that several vehicles were impounded and criminal cases were registered in connection with election-related violations. Four people have been arrested, according to the information placed before the court.

The court's observations came amid concerns over large vehicle cavalcades being used during campaigning. It questioned how such groups of vehicles, including some without number plates, were allowed to



(Left to right) Students gather at North Campus, girl students showing their identity cards while casting their votes at Miranda House and Security personnel keeping watch at North Campus during the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections for 2026-2027 in New Delhi on Friday



PANKAJ KUMAR/PTI

DUSU polls: ABVP, NSUI trade allegations of violations on voting day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University Student Union (DUSU) polls on Friday saw student groups ABVP and NSUI trade allegations of violations, with both sides claiming attempts to influence the voting process and action against their workers. The ABVP alleged that an NSUI worker was caught distributing an incorrect ABVP panel number shortly before voting and was handed over to the police. It said such attempts could confuse students and called for action against those involved.

In a post on X, the ABVP alleged that NSUI workers were continuing such "shameful tactics" even on election day and said the worker was distributing the wrong ABVP panel number before voting and was handed over to the police by ABVP workers. Former DUSU president and ABVP member Aryan Maan separately alleged that six "outsiders" associated with NSUI entered



Kirori Mal College and attempted to influence the election process.

Maan urged Delhi Police to take immediate cognisance of the matter and ensure strict action against unauthorised entry into the college campus. NSUI national president Vinod Jakhar, meanwhile, alleged that a former national secretary of the organisation was detained by police without any reason during the university elections.

"Why is the Government so afraid of NSUI workers?"

tions got underway in North Campus on Friday.

The election-day mood was visible from the metro station to the college gates, with members of the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), National Students' Union of India (NSUI), All India Students' Association (AISA) and Students' Federation of India (SFI) raising slogans and distributing pamphlets and cards bearing candidates' names.

Groups of students stood outside colleges asking others to vote for particular candidates, while campaigners moved between colleges. Students also gathered at tea and ice-cream stalls after casting their votes, discussing candidates, comparing their choices and debating what changes could the DUSU elections bring on campus.

First-year students were seen in groups, while selfie booths outside colleges drew several students who stopped to take photographs. For some first-time voters, the election was also

their first exposure to the scale of student politics at the university. Several students who had joined the university only around two months ago said their friends influenced them.

The DUSU elections on Friday saw campaign activities that appeared to violate several rules governing student polls, with printed pamphlets scattered around North Campus, vehicle rallies and the distribution of campaign materials around South Campus.

Around North Campus, printed pamphlets bearing candidates' names were scattered on roads and footpaths. People travelling in vehicles threw pamphlets, particularly around Chhatra Marg and near colleges such as Kirori Mal and Hansraj, while students on motorcycles distributed candidate cards as they moved between colleges. In South Campus, SUVs and other vehicles moved around university roads as students campaigned for candidates.

Beyond pamphlets and queues: Hostels, fees and menstrual leave drive student votes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Behind the fluttering campaign pamphlets and long queues outside colleges across North Campus, the issues that followed voters into the DUSU polling booths were quite basic — a room they could afford, a placement after graduation or the right to stay home when menstrual cramps make attending class difficult.

As Delhi University students voted on Friday, conversations with students of several North Campus colleges, including Ramjas College, Hindu College, Hansraj College, Kirori Mal College and the Faculty of Law showed that accommodation, hygiene, menstrual leave, fees, placements, internships and basic student facilities were among the issues informing their choices.

For students coming to Delhi from outside the city, accommodation was not merely a question of convenience. "Hostel and



accommodation are major concerns because not everyone can afford to stay in a private PG. Students come from different backgrounds, and many have to spend a substantial part of their family income just to live near college," a student said.

The concern has acquired greater urgency this year following the Satya Niketan building collapse, which killed seven people, including five students. Student accommodation and the safety of private paying-guest facilities have since become a prominent issue in the DUSU campaign.

For women students, basic campus facilities and menstrual leave were among the more immediate concerns. Students raised issues ranging from clean drinking water and hygienic washrooms to female hygiene facilities and the need for menstrual leave.

"Menstrual issues are not a gimmick. Cramps are not a gimmick."

"If a student is in severe pain, she may genuinely not be able to attend class. If menstrual leave can be provided, there is no reason to make an issue out of something so basic," a third-year student of Hindu

College said.

Another student pointed to the gap between what students are charged and what they can actually use. Gargi, a student of Hansraj College, said fee hikes had become a concern, particularly when students felt the additional money was not reflected in campus facilities.

"The year before last, the BA Programme fee was around Rs 29,000, and this year it is Rs 32,000. We are getting essentially the same facilities, so I do not understand the need for the hike," she said.

For first-year students, the concerns extended beyond basic facilities to what college life offered outside the classroom.

"Fests never happen in Hansraj" (College). Placements are also a major concern because, especially in a college like Hansraj (College), students want to know what opportunities they will have after graduation," Anshi, a BA (Honours) Economics student of the college, said.

Govt clears ₹300 crore for e-bus charging infra at seven depots

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant move towards electrifying its entire public transport bus fleet, the Delhi Government has approved Rs 300 crore for the development of e-bus charging infrastructure at seven depots in the South West areas of the city.

The Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) currently operates over 5,000 e-buses and the Delhi Government plans to expand its fleet to 14,000 e-buses by 2029.

To facilitate the addition of regular batches of e-buses,



the transport department is working on installing charging infrastructure at the bus depots, of which Delhi has over 50.

In a recent meeting of the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, an amount of over Rs 300 crore was sanctioned for developing charging infrastructure at various DTC and cluster bus depots in Dichaon Kalan, Kairi, Kharkhari Nahar and Ghumanhera areas of South West Delhi.

According to a detailed project report (DPR) prepared by the power discom BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, the work is likely to be completed in 18 months after all the required approvals are granted.

Father of Nithari victim alleges murder after Koli found dead

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

The father of a 15-year-old girl who was among the young victims killed in the Nithari case questioned the death of Surendra Koli in Haridwar on Friday, alleging that the former accused had been murdered and did not die by suicide.

The Nithari case came to light in 2006 after skeletal remains, skulls and bones were recovered from the backyard and drains near a bungalow in Sector 31, Noida.

The discovery exposed the disappearance and killings of several children and young women and triggered



Nithari case accused Surendra Koli is seen taken to a CBI court from Dasna Jail in Ghaziabad in this file image dated 12 May, 2010

PTI

nationwide outrage.

"Surendra Koli has been murdered; he has not died by suicide," said Jhabbu Lal (64), whose daughter went missing in the summer of 2005 and later, her skeleton was discovered.

Koli was found hanging at a rented tea stall on Sapt Sarovar Road in Haridwar on Friday. Police said a forensic team examined the scene and that the death appeared prima facie to be a case of suicide. The body has been

taken into custody and panchnama and post-mortem proceedings are underway.

Lal, however, questioned why Koli would take such a step after spending several months outside prison following his release.

"If he had died by suicide in jail, it could be understood that he was depressed. But he took his life after being released and spending several months outside? This raises questions," he said.

"He would have been about to disclose some important information. That is why he has been killed," Lal alleged.

He also claimed that Koli was not the main culprit in

the Nithari case and asserted that businessman Moninder Singh Pandher, at whose Sector 31 house Koli worked as a domestic help, was the main accused.

"Koli was not the main culprit. His owner Moninder Pandher was the main accused in the case. He should be hanged," Lal said.

Lal and his wife Sunita (61) have spent nearly two decades seeking justice for their daughter. The couple, originally from Uttar Pradesh's Unnao district, moved to Nithari around four decades ago in search of work. Lal earned his livelihood by ironing clothes for residents in the area.



Youth Power

Driving the Vision of Viksit Bharat

An initiative to connect the youth
with nation-building through government services

ROZGAR MELA

Across 45 locations nationwide, appointment letters
will be distributed to
51,000+ selected candidates for government jobs

by

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

(through video conferencing)



Saturday, 19th September, 2026



12:30 PM



Mass Distribution of Employment Appointment Letters by
the Government of India and Participating State Governments



Equal Opportunities Through Recruitment Examinations
in 13 Regional Languages



Strict Law Against Paper Leaks — Establishment of Special
Fast-Track Courts, Time-Bound Investigation, and Speedy Trial



Talented youth have employment opportunities
in the private sector through UPSC's 'Pratibha Setu' Portal.



Appointments Through Prominent Recruitment Agencies Such
as UPSC, SSC, Railway Recruitment Boards (RRBs), and IBPS



Empowering Youth Aspirations Through a Transparent, Timely
and Merit-Based Recruitment Process



Strengthening Examination Credibility with Aadhaar-Based
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Moody's raises India GDP forecast

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Giving a thumbs up to India's economic growth, Moody's Ratings on Friday sharply raised India's GDP growth forecast for the fiscal year to 7 per cent – the fastest growth rate among all G20 economies-- aided by economic resilience in the face of West Asia conflict but flagged risks to inflation from elevated oil prices and El Nino.

The agency warned that El Nino-related disruptions could increase food price pressures, weighing on private consumption and economic activity. In a statement issued after a periodic review of India's Baa3 sovereign rating, Moody's said the "muted" fiscal policy response to the West Asia shock reflects the Government's commitment to reducing fiscal deficit to 4.3 per cent of GDP in the current fiscal, from 4.4 per cent in FY26. "The economy's demonstrated resilience to the global shock wrought by the conflict in the Middle East has driven an upward revision to our forecast for real GDP growth in fiscal 2026-27 (year ending March 2027) to 7 per cent from 6 per cent previously," Moody's said.

The 7 per cent FY27 GDP growth estimate compares with 6.7 per cent projected by the RBI, 6.6 per cent by S&P Global Ratings and 6.4 per cent by Fitch Ratings.

The Indian economy grew at 7.8 per cent in the previous



Representative image

ISTOCK

fiscal (2025-26). India's real GDP growth accelerated to 8.2 per cent year on year in the first six months of calendar year (CY) 2026, up from 7.3 per cent for the full year in 2025, helped by stronger private consumption, infrastructure investments, and sustained strength in the services sector.

"Although we continue to expect India to grow faster than all other G20 economies, as well as similarly rated emerging market sovereigns, risks remain," Moody's said, adding elevated energy prices could push annual average inflation beyond its 4.8 per cent projection for the fiscal. The average inflation in FY26 was 2.4 per cent. Since the beginning of the war in West

Asia on February 28, crude oil prices have risen significantly, stoking inflation fears. Crude prices have risen over \$100 per barrel this month, from about \$73 level before the war.

While the increased diversification of India's crude import sources, sizeable foreign exchange reserves and strong domestic demand provide important buffers, higher energy and fertiliser import costs, softer external demand and weaker remittance inflows from West Asia could widen the current account deficit and weigh on growth momentum more broadly, Moody's said.

Moody's further said that the stable outlook on India's rating incorporates India's gradual-

ly improving fiscal metrics and resilient growth prospects compared with peers. Moody's has maintained India's rating at 'Baa3' since June 2020. In September, last year, the agency had affirmed the sovereign rating.

Earlier this month, Japanese credit rating agency JCR had upgraded India's sovereign rating to 'A-', a feat achieved after a gap of 35 years, citing solid economic growth and a strong financial system.

Two global rating agencies, S&P and Fitch, had affirmed India's investment-grade rating at 'BBB' and 'BBB-', citing a dynamic and fast-growing, robust economy with policy stability and high infrastructure investments.

NIA court grants bail to Matthew Van Dyke

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A special court of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Friday granted default bail to Matthew Aaron Van Dyke, a US citizen and one of seven foreigners who were arrested in March over allegations that they had provided drone warfare training to ethnic armed groups in Myanmar.

Judge Prashant Sharma of the Special NIA Court released Van Dyke on a personal bond of one lakh rupees with one surety also paying the same amount. He must stay in Delhi and not leave India until the case is concluded, and must appear before investigators whenever they call upon him.

The court said the six Ukrainian co-accused could also apply for bail on the same grounds. Van Dyke, founder of the security company Sons of Liberty International and a former filmmaker in conflict areas, had been detained in Tihar jail since his arrest.

Authorities arrested him on 13 March 2026 at Kolkata airport. The Ukrainians,



Representative image

FILE

Hurba Petro, Slyviak Taras, Ivan Sukmanovskiy, Stefankiv Marian, Honcharuk Maksim and Kaminskyi Viktor -- were intercepted at both Delhi and Lucknow airports. All seven of them entered India on tourist visas in December 2025.

According to the NIA documents, the group was involved in a drone strike on 20 February directed at a Myanmar National Airlines ATR-72 at Myitkyina airport in the Kachin State of Myanmar. The attack damaged the plane but resulted in no injuries.

The NIA says the group flew to Guwahati before travelling to Mizoram without the necessary permits, then crossed the open border between India

and Myanmar into Chin State. According to the investigators, they arrived at Victoria Camp, which is the headquarters of the Kachin Independence Army, where they carried out planned training sessions in the areas of drone operations, assembly, jamming, and asymmetric warfare.

The Chin National Front, the Kachin Independence Army and the Kuki-Chin Army are named in the investigation. The agency also states that drones and equipment from Europe were sent via India to Myanmar, and that the person in question took part in joint combat operations.

The case was initially registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act

after the Ministry of Home Affairs asked the NIA to investigate. Initially, the agency regarded it as a wider terror conspiracy involving ethnic armed organisations which might have connections with the northeast part of India.

However, on 8 September the NIA submitted a chargesheet under Sections 21 and 23 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, for offences concerning illegal entry, stay and movement. These offences may be resolved at the Foreigners Regional Registration Office.

The chargesheet stated that more time was needed to complete the UAPA investigation, including forensic examination of the seized devices and recovered drones. That aspect of the investigation remains open, and another chargesheet may be filed.

As the period of legal custody ended and only immigration offences remained, Van Dyke became eligible for default bail. He applied on 17 September; the court heard the case the next day and granted him bail. The court will look at the chargesheet on 1 October.

India picks Marathi movie *Gondhal* for Oscars

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Marathi film *Gondhal* has been chosen as India's official entry to the Oscars 2027, the Film Federation of India announced on Friday. Written and directed by Santosh Davakhar, the film is set in rural Maharashtra and plays out over a night of a traditional ritual centred around a newly-wed couple.

The film was chosen as India's submission for Best International Feature category for the 99th Academy Awards from a list of 33 films, said P Sheshadri, chairperson of the selection committee. "This year we've had four Marathi films, 14 Hindi films, and others films, all the films were good.

It's a happy moment for Indian cinema, for Marathi cinema. This time the official entry is *Gondhal*," Sheshadri said at a press conference here. "We've watched 33 films in last ten days of different languages. There were many other good films for which we were debating about. *Angh* and *Ikkis* were in top three list apart from



Anuj Prabhu in *Gondhal*

IMDB

Gondhal," he added.

Gondhal had its world premiere at the 56th International Film Festival of India (IFFI) in Goa in 2025 in the Indian Panorama segment. Davakhar won the Silver Peacock for Best

Director at the festival.

Set against the midnight carnival of the ritualistic Gondhal dance in rural Maharashtra, the movie follows Suman, a woman trapped in an oppressive marriage, who plots a murder and an escape with her forbidden lover, blurring the lines between devotion, deception and fate.

Actor Ishita Deshmukh plays the lead role in the movie which also features Kishor Kadam, Yogesh Sohani, Nishad Bhoir, Anuj Prabhu and Dhru Thoke. Veteran composer Ilaiyaraaja has scored music for the film.

"We had many other films from the other parts of India, but we have some regulations and criteria to send film to Oscars... Actually, the film should represent Indian culture, Indian ethos. In those aspects, *Gondhal* stands first among the others. Also, the filmmaking, the use of music and songs, the performances and the human content they want to present on the screen. In all those criteria, *Gondhal* was the best film among the others this year," he said.

Symbol stripped, Mamata faces her...

The development came hours after the ECI allotted the Banerjee-led faction the name Mamata All India Trinamool Congress and a new symbol for the October 6 bypolls. According to the ECI order, the rival group got the name Democratic Trinamool Congress. In an interim order issued on Thursday night, the ECI directed the two sides not to use the party name, All India Trinamool Congress (AITC), and its *Jora Ghash Phul* (two flowers with grass) symbol for the bypolls, and asked them to submit their preferred names and emblems by Friday morning. The last time the ECI froze a party's name and symbol was in October 2022, in the case of the Shiv Sena's name and bow and arrow symbol amid the Uddhav Thackeray-Eknath Shinde split.

Banerjee hit out at the ECI over its decision to freeze the TMC's name and symbol, and said the move was arbitrary.

She accused the BJP of trying to destroy Opposition parties in the country. Describing the development as a black day for democracy, Banerjee questioned the ECI's decision to freeze the party's traditional two flowers and grass symbol, which she said had been associated with the organisation for 28 years. "How can they (EC) freeze my symbol, which has been with us since the beginning for the last 28 years?" she said. "The BJP has looted the elections not in Bengal but also in other States and is now trying to destroy Opposition parties," she alleged.

Opposition leaders criticised the ECI after it barred Banerjee from using the name and symbol of the party she founded, and prompted a swift outreach by Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, who spoke with Banerjee to express solidarity. She later said that the Congress and her party were ready to work together against the Union Government. "We are in this together. We want BJP to be removed," Banerjee said about her conversation with Rahul Gandhi.

Rahul who reportedly told the former CM that his party was ready to extend any assistance required, later led his party's attack on the ECI. "First Shiv Sena, then NCP, and now Trinamool Congress. Every time, the same pattern -- BJP and the ECI join forces to split a party. Then its election symbol is snatched away. When an entire party can be stolen, it's hardly surprising that the votes of millions of Indians can be stolen too," Rahul said, a reference to the split in the two Maharashtra parties.

"The ECI's constitutional responsibility is to protect the mandate-but instead, it's aiding those very forces that overturn the people's verdict," he added, calling the issue a fight for every political party and voter seeking free and fair elections. The outreach marks a notable political shift, given that Banerjee has traditionally maintained closer ties with Sonia Gandhi and contested the state assembly elections earlier this year

on its own.

The BJP slammed Rahul for accusing the ruling party of Government *chori* and party *chori* over the TMC symbol row, and said the Congress leader should look at his own party's history first to realise how it "finished" opposition parties and "toppled" their governments when it was in power. The October 6 bypoll was necessitated after Adhikari vacated the Nandigram seat to retain Bhowanipore-Mamata Banerjee's traditional bastion-where he had defeated the then chief minister in the West Bengal assembly elections held in April.

NEET-UG leak: SC judges to visit NTA

The bench directed that the affidavit filed by the NTA must be uploaded on its website, so that people can make their suggestions.

It also asked the Government to appoint a nodal counsel, where people can submit their suggestions.

On August 19, observing that there is a need to institutionalise the reforms in the NTA, the SC directed the Government to inform it about the steps taken to implement the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan panel and the Nilekani committee.

The SC was hearing a batch of petitions, including one filed by advocate Tanvi Dubey on behalf of the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA).

The seven-member Radhakrishnan Committee was set up by the Ministry of Education in the wake of the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak to make recommendations on reforms in the examination process, improvement in data security protocols and the structure and functioning of the NTA.

After the students' protest in July this year, the Union Government set up a high-powered task force led by Infosys co-founder Nilekani to suggest structural reforms in competitive examinations.

The NTA on May 12 cancelled the NEET-UG 2026 held on May 3 following allegations of paper leaks. The matter is being probed by the Central Bureau of Investigation.

A re-test was held on June 21, and the results were announced on July 16.

After questions of NEET-UG were allegedly leaked in 2024, the SC had refused to cancel the test, but passed various directions aimed at tackling paper leaks and also a criterion for cancelling public exams.

The man who shaped the Red Corridor

The movement grew to cover more than a hundred districts. Even now, security forces still hold him responsible for the violence during

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those years, including the 2010 Dantewada ambush and the 2013 Jhiram Valley massacre of Congress leaders in Chhattisgarh. In November 2018, he stepped down, saying he was getting older and had illnesses such as asthma and diabetes. He handed over leadership to Nambala Keshava Rao, also known as Basavaraju. After that, he disappeared from public view. Officials thought he might return when Basavaraju was killed in Abujmahad in May 2025, but he did not. Former commanders who surrendered say they last saw him at a jungle meeting in 2023. Since then, even those who spent years underground with him say they do not know where he is. One said that only Basavaraju knew his new identity and location, but that link is now gone.

The movement he started has collapsed, and many operations have cleared the forests. Most of the top leaders have either surrendered or been killed. The courts are closing old cases, and a court in Raipur recently gave the death sentence to ten Maoists for the Jhiram Valley attack.

Authorities now say the Naxal insurgency is quiet again in its old strongholds, something that has not happened in sixty years.

The details of Ganapati's case are still unclear. Police have stopped searching for him in the Dandakaranya forests, saying they have already checked the area.

A reward is still offered for information leading to his arrest. Family members in Jagtial, who say they have not seen him for over forty years, have asked him to surrender.

He has not responded. Those who looked for him recall near misses that now sound like legends: a crowded railway platform, a tip from Bijapur that proved useless, and a town in Telangana that had emptied before the teams got there.

Almost everyone who worked in those areas has a story about Ganpati. Ironically, he taught others how to disappear, and now, with the party gone and the forests under control, he seems to be doing the same. Even though India says the insurgency is over, the man who led it for so long is still officially missing. Only one photograph, many names, and a silence that has lasted longer than the conflict remain.

High Court sacks Danam Nagender

The High Court ruled that Nagender's disqualification would take effect from April 23, 2024. It also directed that the judgement be communicated to the Assembly Secretary, Speaker and the Election Commission.

The court declined a plea from Nagender's counsel seeking suspension of the order to enable him to challenge the verdict before the Supreme Court.

Meanwhile, Danam Nagender elected from Khairatabad in the 2023 Assembly elections as

a BRS candidate. He subsequently joined the Congress and contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election from Secunderabad on a Congress ticket. He lost the election to BJP candidate and Union Minister G Kishan Reddy.

The disqualification dispute arose under the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, which deals with defection by elected legislators. The petitions against Nagender, filed by the BRS legislators, were examined by the Speaker in his capacity as the authority dealing with such matters.

In March this year, the Speaker dismissed the disqualification petition, stating that the evidence presented before him was not sufficient to establish that Nagender has voluntarily relinquished his BRS membership.

Maheshwar Reddy and Kaushik Reddy subsequently moved the High Court challenging the Speaker's order. Following arguments from all sides, the Division Bench reserved its judgment in August and pronounced its decision on Friday. Responding to the Telangana High Court's decision against him, Khairatabad MLA Danam Nagender said that he had no intention of approaching the Supreme Court.

Speaking on the judgement, Danam Nagender said that he will accept the High Court's decision. He stated that he had reached this position after facing several political battles. He expressed confidence that he could once again fight an election and secure victory with the support of the people. He said that contesting elections was not new to him and that he was prepared to face the people and fight it out politically.

Years after Nithari killings acquittal...

Various aspects are being investigated to ascertain the exact cause of death.

Koli was originally from Mangrukhal in the Almora district. To improve his family's financial situation, he moved to Delhi in 2004-05 in search of employment. He worked for Maninder Singh Pandher in Noida and in 2006, the disappearance of several children and women and the discovery of human skeletons in Nithari caused a nationwide sensation. During the investigation, Koli's name emerged as one of the main accused. He faced trial in the case, from the lower court to the high court. The Allahabad High Court sentenced him to death, which was later commuted to life imprisonment. After a protracted legal battle, in 2025, the Supreme Court acquitted him in the Nithari case due to lack of evidence.

Koli's death, however, has raised questions, with the father of one of the victims claiming that it was murder, not suicide.

Jhabbu Lal's 15-year-old daughter went missing in the summer of 2005, and her skeleton was discovered in 2006, bringing her name into the list of the Nithari killings.

Lal (64) questioned why Koli would take such a drastic step after spending several months

outside prison following his release.

"If he had died by suicide in jail, it could be understood that he was depressed. But he took his life after being released and spending several months outside? This raises questions," he said.

Lal speculated that Koli might have been about to disclose important information, which could be why he was killed.

He also claimed that Koli was not the main culprit in the Nithari case and asserted that Pandher was the main accused. "He should be hanged," Lal insisted.

"If the government helps us, only then will we be able to continue our fight in future. We can't fight on our own," he added.

Lal and his wife Sunita (61) have spent nearly two decades seeking justice for their daughter. The couple, originally from Uttar Pradesh's Unnao district, moved to Nithari around four decades ago looking for work.

ABVP sweeps early DUSU trends

The presidential field alone included seven names, Ananya Raturi, Ashmit Kumar, Ejay Mansuri, Samarth Beniwal, Sameer Kumar, Vijay Shankar Meena of NSUI and Yash Dabas of ABVP, with ABVP looking to build on its 2025 showing, when it won three of the four central panel seats.

Turnout through the day tracked patterns seen in recent years, when overall participation has typically settled between 30 and 35 per cent, with individual colleges such as Miranda House regularly posting far higher numbers, over 60 per cent in 2025, on the strength of dense on-campus voting drives. The day was not without disruption. At LC-2 (Morning), three students allegedly attempted to vote using fake ID cards. Security personnel caught one of them on the spot and recovered the counterfeit card from her, while two others managed to leave before they could be detained. Preliminary questioning of the student who was caught reportedly revealed she identified herself as belonging to NSUI. Given the seriousness of the matter, action is being initiated against the detained student, the two who fled, and the person who allegedly brought them to the polling centre, with ABVP demanding immediate action from the administration and the proctorial team, who assured necessary steps would follow, after which ABVP workers called off their protest at the spot.

Early results trickling in from individual colleges through the day pointed to a strong ABVP showing. The organisation swept all four seats at Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar College, won three seats, president, vice president and secretary, by a wide margin at Keshav Mahavidyalaya, and took the president and secretary posts along with two central councillor seats at Shyama Prasad Mukherjee College. At SRCC, ABVP candidates won the president and secretary posts along with both councillor seats.

States Focus



PM TO OPEN INTERNATIONAL CLIMATE CONFERENCE IN DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate an international conference on the environment and climate here on Saturday, which will be attended by environmental experts, Supreme Court judges, legal experts and senior Government officials.

The two-day meet during the weekend on “The Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics” is being organised by the National Green Tribunal. It will witness the participation of environmental experts, judges of the Supreme Court of India and high courts, district court judges, secretaries of various ministries, senior Government officials, representatives of State judicial academies, an official statement said. It will also bring together eminent judges and judicial representatives from 17 countries. The conference will provide a platform for the exchange of judicial approaches, scientific knowledge, environmental governance practices across jurisdictions. (PTI)



YOGA OFFERS BALANCE, AMID STRESS OF TECH-DRIVEN LIFE: VP

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Friday said yoga provides balance, awareness and concentration amid the stress caused by technology-driven lifestyles and the fast pace of modern life.

Addressing the 75th anniversary celebrations of the Gordhandas Seksaria College of Yoga and Cultural Synthesis at Kaivalyadhama, Radhakrishnan said yoga helps establish balance between the mind, body and spirit, and enables people to lead healthier lives.

“In today’s stressful lifestyle, yoga gives a person an opportunity to pause, think, focus on one’s breath and reconnect with oneself,” he said, adding that yoga helps improve concentration and maintain balance between the mind and body. Radhakrishnan said the teachings of Maharshi Patanjali remained relevant even in an age marked by a continuous flow of information. (PTI)

Karnataka gives Tulu official status

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mangaluru (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday announced that Tulu would be made the State’s second additional administrative language in Udupi and Dakshina Kannada districts. He also said that the Government has decided on a new tourism policy covering the Malnad and coastal regions.

The policy envisages treating tourism projects in the regions as infrastructure projects and providing incentives to attract investment, besides giving investors more time to repay loans, Shivakumar said after the Cabinet meeting held in Mangaluru.

“Today, we have decided to make Tulu a language applicable to Udupi and Dakshina Kannada districts and to declare it as the state’s second additional (administrative) language,” he said. The CM said the Tulu language spoken primarily in Dakshina Kannada and Udupi districts carries the potential for educational and cultural growth.

A Cabinet note shared by the Chief Minister’s Office said it would be the “second additional administrative language”.



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar

Shivakumar also said the state Government would bring out a separate tourism policy for coastal Karnataka given its long coastline, rich cultural tradition, religious and heritage sites.

He said those investing in the tourism sector, particularly in greenfield projects, needed greater support as prolonged monsoons affected tourism activity in the coastal and Malnad regions.

“Those who invest in tourism — because this is a full greenfield sector — should be given greater support. They should be given time to repay their loans,” he said.

The policy will cover the Malnad and coastal regions and several incentives have already been decided, he said, adding that tourism projects would be treated as

infrastructure projects.

The Government would also undertake new urban development planning and provide incentives related to fisheries, he said.

Shivakumar said the Government has approved the Karnataka Marine Biotechnology Policy, 2026-31. Under the policy, the Government will establish the Fisheries, Marine and Blue Economy University by upgrading the existing college and increasing its intake from the existing 60 seats to 200.

On the demand to rename Dakshina Kannada district as Mangaluru district, the chief minister said the Government would issue a draft notification and invite public opinion for a month.

“We have more or less come to the view that

Dakshina Kannada district should be declared as Mangaluru district. But public opinion is also necessary here,” he said.

The Government would take into account people’s sentiments and the traditional aspects associated with the name before taking a final decision, Shivakumar said. He said the Cabinet had given approvals totalling around ₹32,611 crore — about ₹16,000 crore for rural development and another ₹16,000 crore for Mangaluru, Udupi and the coastal region. Several demands submitted by MLAs, MPs, the Chamber of Commerce, fishermen, industries and trade bodies had been considered while taking the decisions, he said.

Shivakumar also announced that the Government would hold Cabinet meetings at 10 to 12 places across Karnataka over the next 15 months.

“We want to see the entire state. Wherever there is a position, wherever there is a need, we will have to go, because every part of the state is important for us,” he said, describing the approach as “Samagra Karnataka, Samruddha Karnataka” (Inclusive Karnataka-Prosperous Karnataka).

TMC symbol row: BJP rejects Congress’s party *chori* charge



BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP hit back at Rahul Gandhi on Friday for accusing the ruling party of “Government *chori*” and “party *chori*” over the TMC symbol row, and said the Congress leader should look at his own party’s history first to realise how it “finished” Opposition parties and “toppled” their Governments when it was in power.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters here, party spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi accused the Congress of toppling Governments led by HD Deve Gowda, Chaudhary Charan Singh, Chandra Shekhar and IK Gujral by abruptly withdrawing support.

“Before levelling allegations against the BJP, Rahul Gandhi should first look at the history of his own party. If Rahul Gandhi does not know the history of his own party, he does not deserve to be a leader in his party, leave aside continuing as the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha,” Trivedi said.

He said the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) is the only party in the country which has never witnessed a “vertical division”.

The BJP and the Bharatiya Jana Sangh also stood firm to protect democratic values whenever the Congress attacked those, he added.

The Congress on Friday expressed firm support to the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC

after the Election Commission (EC) froze the party’s name and symbol amid an ongoing dispute between two of its rival factions, with Gandhi alleging that after “vote *chori*” and “Government *chori*”, now “party *chori*” is taking place.

Rallying behind the former West Bengal chief minister, the Congress leader asserted that this fight is not just Banerjee’s but it is the fight of every political party, every voter who wants free and fair elections.

Gandhi’s remarks came a day after the ECI directed the rival factions of the TMC not to use the party name and symbol for upcoming bypolls in West Bengal, and to submit their preferred alternative names and symbols to the poll panel.

Lashing out at Gandhi, Trivedi said, “During its rule till 1997, the Congress did not allow any elected Government of other parties to complete its full term. When it had the power to do so.

“It dismissed the EMS Namboodiripad Government in Kerala (in 1959). It finished the Praja Socialist Party in 1963. In 1984, the Congress engineered a split within the National Conference, thereby causing a rift in the party. The Congress dismantled the NT Rama Rao Government when the Telugu Desam Party leader was away for medical treatment. The Congress engineered divisions in Karpur Thakur’s Lok Dal party in Bihar.”

Dharma different from religion: Bhagwat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ujjain

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Friday said India’s understanding of the concept of *dharma* was distinct from Western notions of religion, asserting that the country has not discriminated among different faiths and this was its understanding of secularism.

Addressing around 1,700 Gen Z participants at the “Yuva Dharma Sansad” in Ujjain, Bhagwat said he was happy to see youngsters discussing *dharma* at a time when some considered it an old people’s affair.



“Our state has always been intermingling. It does not discriminate among its people. This is the meaning of *panth-nirpekshata* for us,” he said.

Bhagwat said the Western concept of secularism emerged from conflicts

between rulers and religious authorities, and therefore, did not fit the Indian context in the same manner.

Bhagwat said a person’s ego can create a misconception that everything operates according to his authority and that he can control

everything.

“Take the Sun, for example. Its rising and setting are certain. Man, in his arrogance, believes that everything runs by his own authority. And because of that, he carries the misconception that even such things should and do move according to his own will. But that’s not the case. You cannot do anything about it,” the RSS chief said.

Bhagwat did not name anyone, but Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said on X, “Is he referring to a supposed non-biological being whose avatara diwas was just celebrated?”

Govt doing needful on drought: Maharashtra CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday said his Government is taking the drought-like situation in the State seriously and was coming up with measures to deal with it and provide relief to farmers.

Speaking to reporters about NCP (SP) supremo Sharad Pawar’s letter on the prevailing situation due to lack of adequate rain, Fadnavis said his Government would consider suggestions made by the former Union agriculture minister.

“Pawar saheb is a senior leader. It is a matter of happiness he has sent a letter. I do not want to give any political colour to it. I feel the state Government is doing what it needs to do. If we have received suggestions from him, or if he has given us sug-



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis

gestions in such a situation, we will certainly listen to them,” he said.

Pawar had urged Fadnavis to take immediate measures in view of the rainfall deficit and crop losses in several parts of Maharashtra. The veteran leader has sought, among other measures, declaration of drought in severely affected areas and financial assistance of ₹50,000 per hectare for farmers.

The chief minister made it clear that the State would

provide assistance to farmers without waiting for financial help under the National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF).

The crop damage assessment required for a NDRF proposal (for relief) would be undertaken after October 5, Fadnavis added.

Asked about Congress leader Rahul Gandhi’s criticism of the Election Commission of India’s decision in the Trinamool Congress case, Fadnavis said

the “mentality” of the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha is “anarchist” and his objective was to undermine constitutional institutions.

On Thursday, the ECI temporarily removed the All India Trinamool Congress name and its ‘flowers and grass symbol’ from the ballot during the October 6 West Bengal bypolls, barring both rival factions from using the political identity associated with Mamata Banerjee and her party for nearly three decades.

Gandhi’s objective is that people’s trust in constitutional bodies is lost, and once that happens then trust in democracy itself will also be lost, Fadnavis said.

Gandhi is taking the Constitution in his hand and then sowing the idea that faith in it should be lost, the CM alleged.

Congress attacks PM on CBI probe against Arunachal CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Friday came down heavily upon Prime Minister Narendra Modi claiming that in a show of “complete hypocrisy”, Pema Khandu has been allowed to continue as Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister despite the Supreme Court ordering a CBI inquiry into contracts worth ₹1,270 crore awarded by him as PWD minister to his family members.

In a post on X, Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said Khandu should have immediately resigned or been asked to resign, alleging that this was another example of allowing corruption to flourish and making money.

“But both the CM and his Supreme Leader the PM



Congress general secretary in-charge of communications Jairam Ramesh

decided to brazen it out,” he said.

Ramesh said the Supreme Court had ordered a CBI inquiry on April 6 into contracts worth ₹1,270 crore awarded by Khandu as the Arunachal Pradesh PWD minister to his family members between 2015 and 2025. The Supreme Court directive had come as a sur-

prise to the Modi Government, he said.

According to the Congress leader, the Supreme Court summoned top officials of the Arunachal Pradesh Government on August 3 because the CBI complained that the State Government was not cooperating with the inquiry.

“The CM (who has contin-

ued as PWD minister) was denying access to the relevant files. The HM was reportedly taken aback by the CBI’s new-found courage,” Ramesh said.

On August 24, the Supreme Court observed that instead of providing relevant documents, the state had supplied huge chunks of documents to the CBI, he said. “It is extraordinary and totally unacceptable that the CM continues in office. This shows the complete hypocrisy of the PM.

“Yet another example of ‘*khaya hai, khane diya hai aur khilwaya bhi hai*,’” the Rajya Sabha MP said, hitting out at the prime minister who has said a number of times in the past regarding checking corruption that “*Na khaunga, na khane dunga*”.

The next hearing in the case is on September 25, Ramesh said.

Former TN minister Anbil Mahesh questioned in school approval scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Former School Education minister Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi on Friday appeared before the Chennai Central Crime Branch police here for questioning in connection with the private school approval fraud case.

The DMK leader against whom the CCB has registered a Prevention of Corruption Act case, was accompanied by his advocates. The police questioned him for over an hour, a source said.

The summons follow an intensive eight-hour search on Wednesday by the CCB at the residences and premises of the DMK leader in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli over his alleged involvement in a ₹100 crore bribery scam where money was allegedly collected from 177 private school managements in exchange



Former School Education minister of TN Anbil Mahesh Poyyamozhi

for permanent Government recognition.

As many as 118 items including property deeds, bank statements, 18 mobile phones, laptops and tablets were seized during the raid which was initiated following a complaint by a private school association. The police arrested one BT Arasakumar and two others in June.

Later, responding to the

searches, Anbil Mahesh denied allegations levelled against him and termed the raid as “political vendetta” and diversionary tactics by the ruling TVK. He had claimed that the action on him followed his public speeches criticising the state Government’s plan to establish a new Secretariat Assembly complex at an estimated cost of ₹1,200 crore.

Rajnath calls for indigenous technology, public-private synergy in aviation sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday called for the development of an ecosystem that can address the requirements of both the civil and military aviation sectors.

He said indigenously developed technologies were essential in view of the changing nature of warfare.

“We need to develop an ecosystem that can effectively address the requirements of both the civil and military aviation sectors,” Singh said during the handing-over ceremony of Light Combat Aircraft Tejas twin-seater trainers and Hindustan Turbo Trainer-40 basic trainer aircraft to the Indian Air Force and Dhruv Next Generation helicopters to Pawan Hans Limited at



Defense Minister Rajnath Singh addresses an event, in Kochi, Kerala

Hindustan Aeronautics Limited.

Developing technologies indigenously is the need of the hour for India, as the nature of warfare is chang-

ing rapidly, he said. He underlined that public and private sectors should not be viewed as competitors but as organisations that complement each other.

Four cubs born at Kuno in MP, India’s cheetah count rises to 56

GIRISH SHARMA ■ Bhopal

On the fourth anniversary of Project Cheetah on September 17, India counted 52 surviving cheetahs, 32 of them born on Indian soil. A day later, Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh added four more to that tally, marking a new chapter in the country’s ambitious cheetah reintroduction programme.

India-born female cheetah KGP12 gave birth to four cubs on September 18 at Kuno in Sheopur district, taking India’s cheetah population to 56 and the number of India-born cheetahs to 36. According to Kuno management, the mother and all four cubs were safe in the initial assessment and were being monitored.

The birth is significant because KGP12 herself was born in India. That means the



programme has moved beyond the first generation of translocated African cheetahs to a stage where India-born animals are producing the next generation. In conservation terms, the development is being seen as an important indicator of natural population growth.

Union Environment Minister Bhopendra Yadav called it a “historic and joyous moment” for Project Cheetah and said the four new lives symbolised hope, resilience and the growing success of cheetah conservation in India.

Editor's

TAKE

US tariffs: India's Russian oil dilemma

The challenge for India is no longer simply about managing tariffs, but balancing cheap Russian crude, energy costs and the broader India-US trade relationship

The US Congress has done what the courts undid. This week, the US House passed the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026 by 262-159, following the Senate's 86-11 vote in August - sending to Donald Trump's desk a law authorising tariffs of up to 100 per cent on the five largest buyers of Russian oil and gas. India tops that list, alongside China, Azerbaijan, Hungary and Slovakia. For New Delhi, a wound barely healed has been reopened.

This is not a repeat of 2025's overreach. The Supreme Court struck down Trump's IEEPA-based "reciprocal" tariffs in February, ruling that only Congress can levy duties - which is precisely why this bill matters more. It is a statute, not an executive whim, and far harder to litigate away. Yet its bite is deliberately calibrated: an early draft proposed a blanket 500 per cent on any Russian energy buyer; what survived is discretionary, waivable by the President, with the "top five" list revisited every 180 days.

Graham, who championed it for over a year, did not live to see it pass - he died in July, and the bill now carries his name. The stakes for India are real. It imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude, and Russia now supplies over half of that - a record share, reached after a year of tariff pressure, not despite it. India spent \$40.8 billion on Russian crude in FY26, chasing discounts that have saved precious foreign exchange. Yet the US remains India's largest export market: \$42.8 billion in goods between April and August alone, still growing. A comprehensive bilateral trade deal remains unsigned, with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal holding out for tariff parity with Vietnam and Bangladesh.

Can this be negotiated? Almost certainly. Washington has traded away this exact threat before: in February, a near-identical 25 per cent Russia-linked penalty was lifted after a Modi-Trump understanding, only for Russian imports to climb back to record levels once the pressure eased. Trade analysts expect Trump to sign it, then hold the authority in reserve as leverage for future talks, not fire it immediately.

Neither India nor China is likely to walk away from discounted Russian barrels simply because Washington has raised the ceiling. Russian oil matters to India's import bill, not to its energy security. Hardeep Singh Puri has repeatedly noted that Gulf producers, the US, Brazil and Guyana can absorb a shift - India ran on negligible Russian crude before 2022 and adapted once already. The dependency today is economic convenience, not necessity.

India's wisest course is calibrated, not capitulatory: treat the bill's own waiver clause as the anchor for finally closing the trade agreement, trading a genuine, verifiable diversification path - more US crude and LPG, more Gulf and Latin American barrels - for durable preferential access, rather than symbolic pledges that unravel within months.

Alongside this, New Delhi must keep building strategic reserves and a wider supplier base, so that Washington's leverage shrinks with time regardless of how this round ends. Quiet diplomacy, not public defiance or premature surrender, will serve India best.

Satya Niketan: More than a building collapse

The deaths of seven young students in a Delhi PG collapse cannot be reduced to illegal construction and negligent owners. The tragedy exposes a deeper national failure: inadequate educational infrastructure, unsafe student housing and a system that too often places profit above the safety and dignity of young Indians



DEBASISH BHATTACHARYYA

VALSON THAMPU

The story so far: The tragic collapse of an illegal, multi-storied PG accommodation in New Delhi, which has claimed the lives of seven young people has understandably triggered widespread public outrage.

The arrests of the owners of the killer structure are necessary and welcome, but insufficient as a remedial response, especially if such tragedies are not to recur. "Greedy for rental income, owners built extra floors," reads one headline. Perhaps the larger point we are missing is this: it is not the greed of the PG owners alone that caused the tragedy; it is the product of a greedy system operating under the colluding eyes of those whose duty it was to prevent tragedies of this kind. Bigger point: If the discussion centres on illegal construction, negligence, arrests and compensation alone, we will miss the forest for the trees. The collapse of the building is only the visible manifestation of a much deeper crisis: the criminal neglect of education, not just in NCR but countrywide, and the failure to provide safe, adequate and affordable accommodation for students. And this, not because we lacked the required resources, but because we value money above life.

Thanks to the scandalous failure of our education enterprise nationally, Delhi has become an educational refuge for young people from across India. About 50 per cent of the 700,000 students enrolled in DU colleges are from other states. Each one of them, numbering some 350,000, needs accommodation. The infrastructure available to accommodate them is woefully inadequate. Such a state of affairs serves as a goldmine for PG accommodation sharks. This is a national shame. This problem is not unique to Delhi.

A national tragedy

Here's the question that stares us in the face from this tragedy: Why do so many young Indians have to flock to Delhi, leaving their home states in search of better educational opportunities? Surely, such educational migrations are not natural. Many of these students cannot afford to live and study in Delhi. Parents strain their economic resources to the utmost, just because educating their children is their topmost priority. It devastates them to have their children return home dead. And this brings us to an uncomfortable question: Why is education so grossly neglected? It cannot be because India's ruling class does not understand its value. When it comes to their own children,



our ruling elite are keen to provide the best quality education in the most expensive and prestigious universities in the West. Our education system is what it is, not because we lack the political will to educate our children and youths, but because there is a will to patronise the vested interests thriving through this scandalous state of affairs.

The spirit of education

To understand the above, the story of St Stephen's College is worth recalling. Founded in 1881 by five Cambridge missionaries, the college was established at a time when educational opportunities in Delhi were extremely limited, particularly for the poor. The founders had very modest resources. Yet they believed that there was no better way to love a people than to provide educational opportunities to them. To them, education was an out-working of love. If we love, we will respect the worth of the people we love. This activates vigilance in caring for them. To care is not only to preserve the current worth, but also to enhance it, as every parent knows. Education is the best means of enhancing the worth of individuals and nations. The founders of St Stephen's College were animated by a spirit of selfless love - the belief that those who are less privileged deserve not less, but greater care, attention and opportunity. That idea seems to have been lost somewhere along the way.

The St Stephen's story further reveals the extraordinary demand for quality education. The college has only around 400 undergraduate seats, while tens of thousands of students applied. The tragedy was that many of those rejected were among the brightest young people in the country - not because they lacked merit, but simply because there was no room for them. Permission was sought to expand the intake in Economics and to introduce Political Science (Hon) Adequate library and infrastructure facilities were available. Only a limited number of additional teaching posts had to be sanctioned. Yet, despite repeated efforts, the necessary permissions never came.

The prospect of some hundred more young men and women benefiting from quality higher education did not appeal to the 'competent' authorities concerned. It is far easier to

run an illicit PG facility that could kill many an inmate, provided the relevant authorities see scope for 'additional mobilisation of personal resources' in it. Such an experience is not limited to St. Stephen's. The larger truth it exposes is that India has failed to expand educational opportunity - not because the resources were lacking, but because our patriotism falls short of loving the people. We profess, but do not practise, love. At its deepest level, education must not be deemed an industry, a degree-producing mechanism or a speculative investment. It is a domain of public service - a sacred enterprise in human development. To care for the learner is first to recognise their worth and then to do everything possible to enhance it.

Where this concern is absent, education risks becoming an industry rather than an investment in human development. This is why the Delhi incident should force us to ask not merely who violated building regulations, but what kind of society allows young people to live in dangerous conditions simply because they have nowhere else to go or cannot afford safer roofs over their heads. The answer cannot be found only in courts, commissions or administrative inquiries. Those institutions provide temporary justice and relief, but the deeper transformation must come from society itself.

Another dimension to the crisis

The purpose of education should be to equip young people with knowledge and skills that enable them to solve the problems of their society, as Plato envisaged in The Republic.

Education, therefore, should nurture citizens who hold themselves responsible for others - not merely seek personal advancement. The distinction can be expressed simply: missionary or mercenary. A missionary serves because he or she loves the people and cares for them. A mercenary has his or her eyes fixed on what can be gained from the people, unmindful of their safety and welfare. As Shakespeare says, in serving them, he serves only himself.

If education produces increasingly mercenary citizens - people trained only to milk and massage the system to their advantage, no matter at what cost to others - society loses its developmental momentum and moral vitality. The seven young lives lost in Delhi should therefore not become a media will-o'-the-wisp that glows and vanishes from public attention. Their sacrifice should compel us to confront the larger failures: inadequate educational infrastructure, unsafe accommodation, corruption, administrative indifference, and the cynical choice to keep the common man in a fool's paradise, anaesthetised to his real condition by the hypnotic power of propaganda-driven media. The real question is this:

What kind of society forces young people to risk their lives merely to pursue their dreams? Until we answer that question - and act upon the answers that emerge - we may have, God forbid, a procession of Satya Niketan heartbreaks.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Wealth That Cannot Satisfy

Yajnavalkya, a revered sage, once decided to divide his possessions between his two wives before renouncing worldly life. His wife Maitreyi asked him directly, if she possessed the entire earth full of wealth, would it make her immortal? He said no, it would only bring the comforts wealth allows, not immortality. She replied that she had no use, then, for something that would not carry her beyond death, and asked instead to be taught what he knew of the imperishable Self.

Yajnavalkya was moved by her clarity, and explained that everything we love, wealth, relationships, even our own bodies, is dear to us not for its own sake, but because of the Self shining through it. Real fulfilment lies in knowing that Self, not merely accumulating its reflections.

We often chase wealth, relationships and achievements, assuming they will eventually deliver lasting peace, without pausing to ask whether they can.

Today, ask yourself honestly, of everything you are pursuing, what are you truly hoping it will give you, and whether it actually can.

-DAIV



SIDDHARTH ROY

2ND OPINION

A building announces itself to the world through its height, shape and façade. Its foundation, however, remains buried in darkness. No passer-by admires the concrete below the ground or pauses to photograph the piles carrying the weight of a tower. Yet if the foundation is weak, the most beautiful structure is living on borrowed time.

As a civil engineer, I find this a powerful metaphor for human life. We spend much of our lives constructing what others can see: careers, homes, achievements, reputations and social identities. We rarely devote the same attention to what remains invisible - character, patience, integrity, compassion and the quiet discipline that holds a person together.

A structure is not tested on a calm morning. Its real

The foundations we cannot see

test comes when the wind rises, the earth moves or an unexpected load is placed upon it. Human beings, too, reveal their foundations during storms. Bereavement, failure, humiliation, financial hardship and uncertainty strip away appearances. At such moments, neither wealth nor reputation can provide the strength that character must supply.

Engineering teaches another humbling lesson. A foundation cannot be designed merely by looking at the building one wishes to construct. It must respond to the ground beneath it. Human beings often forget this. We compare our lives with others and attempt to reproduce their successes without knowing the soil on which those lives were built. But every person stands on different ground different circumstances, responsibilities, vulnerabilities and dreams.

There is a similar danger in the life of a society. A nation may celebrate highways, skyscrapers, digital networks and impressive economic numbers. But beneath these visible achievements lie less glamorous foundations: functioning institutions, public trust, education, social cohesion, justice and ethical leadership. When these weaken, development can become little more than an impressive façade.

The tragedy is that foundations are usually noticed only after they fail. A crack in a wall may appear suddenly, but the weakness responsible for it may have

developed silently for years. Likewise, the collapse of a relationship, institution or public trust is rarely caused by one moment alone. It is often the final expression of stresses that were ignored for too long.

Perhaps this explains why some of the strongest people are not necessarily the most conspicuous. Their strength has been built quietly - in promises kept when nobody was watching, in kindness offered without expectation, in failures endured without bitterness and in principles maintained when compromise would have been easier.

Modern life encourages us to polish the façade before strengthening the foundation. We ask how successful we appear, how quickly we are progressing and how high we can rise. Perhaps we should occasionally ask a more difficult question: What is holding us up?

Every structure eventually encounters a storm. Every life does too. And when that day comes, the world does not examine the façade. It tests what lies beneath it.

The deepest lesson of engineering may therefore be a profoundly human one: the things that matter most are often the things nobody sees.

The writer is a consultant to Rashtriya Raksha University under the Ministry of Home Affairs, a civil engineer, short story writer, columnist, public policy expert and contemporary affairs commentator

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The screen-time crisis among today's youth

Smartphones have become an inseparable part of modern youth life. From attending online classes and completing academic work to watching films, scrolling through social media and communicating with friends, young people spend much of their day in front of screens. While digital technology has made life easier, excessive screen exposure is becoming a growing concern.

For many, screen time continues well beyond academic or professional work. Entertainment platforms, short-video applications, social media and streaming services often occupy leisure hours. What begins as a few minutes can easily become several hours of continuous viewing, gradually changing how young people spend their free time. Late-night smartphone use is another concern. Watching videos, scrolling through social media or streaming films before sleep can keep users engaged for longer than intended, potentially contributing to irregular sleep, tiredness and reduced attention the next day.

Excessive screen use can reduce time for family, hobbies and outdoor activities. Since screens are essential for education, balance is key. Screen-free periods, regular breaks and physical activity can help young people develop healthier digital habits.

NISARGA CA | UTTAR PRADESH

Yemen crisis raises energy risks

Rapid Houthi advances in Yemen pose a significant strategic risk to Saudi Arabia, while further threatening an already vulnerable global energy supply chain amid sustained turmoil in West Asia.

Saudi Arabia alleged that a Houthi drone was headed towards Mecca on September 15, describing it as the second time the group had targeted the holy city since 2017. Riyadh called the attempted attack a "red line", while the Iran-backed Houthis denied involvement.

The new front in the broader Middle East conflict could have serious consequences for regional security and global oil supplies, particularly as Brent crude prices have risen to their highest level since May. Meanwhile, Saudi Arabia has reportedly shut its East-West pipeline amid the worsening situation in Yemen.

Saudi Arabia could also face a "double choke point" crisis if both the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab al-Mandeb Strait are effectively disrupted.

The escalation will test the recently concluded "Mecca Joint Defence Agreement" involving Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Pakistan. With the US choosing not to intervene directly, regional stakeholders and multilateral forums must pursue dialogue to prevent the situation from developing into another prolonged conflict.

PRASUN KUMAR DUTTA | WEST BENGAL

A setback for digital payments

The government cannot claim that its decision to introduce a 0.4 per cent fee on UPI payments above ₹2,000 will cause no financial burden to people. The merchant discount rate (MDR) is a disincentive not only for merchants but also for customers. Merchants, or at least most of them, are likely to increase product prices to make up for the fees they pay. Further, they may prefer cash over digital UPI payments for transactions above ₹2,000 to avoid charges. The government claims that 96 per cent of UPI merchant transactions fall below ₹2,000 and are 100 per cent charge-free. However, it conveniently conceals the fact that transactions above the threshold account for almost 70 per cent of the total value of UPI transactions. It is difficult to dismiss concerns that the UPI fee could benefit US companies, given that PhonePe and Google Pay account for more than 86 per cent of the market share.

According to the Swadeshi Jagran Manch, the imposition of a UPI fee amounts to demeaning an achievement of Bharat that has won global approbation. The SJM has reminded the government of the "broad savings" made through free-to-use UPI. We urge the government to rethink and roll back the move and keep UPI free of charge.

G DAVID MILTON | TAMIL NADU



A Papilio Clytia butterfly visits a hibiscus flower, in Morigaon district, Assam, PHOTO: PTI

Bihar's floods do not end when the water recedes

Nearly 50 lakh people have been affected by Bihar's latest floods, but the official count captures only the scale of inundation, not the cost of recovery. For thousands of families, the real crisis begins after the waters recede — when damaged homes, lost livelihoods, debt and depleted assets remain



EKLAVYA PRASAD

Bihar is in the grip of another flood season, and the images are painfully familiar: swollen rivers, submerged villages, cut-off roads and families ferried to safety. But behind the visuals lies a number that tells its own story. According to the state's Disaster Management Department, as of September 14, close to 49.71 lakh people — roughly 9.94 lakh households — across 15 districts, 87 blocks and 575 gram panchayats had been affected.

What is striking is the pace. The count stood at barely 0.10 lakh on September 2, then leapt to 17.77 lakh by September 5 and 44.02 lakh by September 9. By September 11, it had crossed 48 lakh — an almost five-hundred-fold jump in nine days — before the increase slowed sharply, reaching 49.71 lakh by September 14.

That slowdown is easy to misread. A flatlining number is not the same as recovery. For a household, a flood's consequences — displacement, a damaged home, a lost harvest and a disrupted livelihood — persist long after it drops out of the daily bulletin.

The real test of flood management is not how many people were counted, but how long it takes them to get their lives back.

For families living through it, the crisis does not end when the water goes down. In many ways, that is when a second one begins. Returning to a damaged home means clearing silt, replacing lost belongings, restoring drinking water and sanitation, and reckoning with dead livestock and ruined land. One household may lose a few possessions; its neighbour may lose land, housing, tools, documents and months of income. Two families in the same flooded village can emerge with entirely different losses — and entirely different capacities to recover.

This is where the administrative lens runs out of road. Counting affected districts, panchayats, people, houses and animals is essential for mounting a response, but it says almost nothing about what happened inside a single home, what was lost, or what recovery would actually require.

That gap became visible in a 2025 household-level assessment of the Phase II floods of 2024, conducted by Megh Pyne Abhiyan with support from Tata Trusts. It covered 2,290 households across 134 wards and 21 panchayats in seven of North Bihar's worst-hit districts. It was not designed to be representative of Bihar as a whole — its purpose was to look past the headline numbers and see how losses were actually experienced, and how they varied by place and by the way the flood struck.

The findings were stark. Surveyed households reported total losses of about ₹126.3 crore — an average of ₹5.51 lakh per household, though the median was just ₹2.11 lakh, a gap that itself shows how unevenly losses fall. Land damage made up ₹55.4 crore of the total, or 47.2 per cent; house damage another ₹42 crore, or 36.2 per cent. Ninety-one per cent of households had cut back on food; 82 per cent had been displaced. Borrowing and selling off assets were common ways of coping.

The point is not the rupee figure itself. It is what the figure implies for recovery: a damaged house needs one kind of help, lost land another, dead livestock a third, and a family that borrowed to buy food may need something else again.

The study went on to identify 12 distinct flood typologies in North Bihar — seven from the original assessment and four more from further analysis. These matter because the way water enters and moves through a settlement — an embankment breach, a river in overflow, clogged drainage, or several rivers interacting — determines the depth, duration and force of the flood, and therefore the shape of the loss. A settlement hit by a sudden embankment breach faces a different order of structural damage from one gradually submerged by clogged drainage, even under the same depth of water. Recovery needs, accordingly, vary just as widely.

That is precisely why treating “immediate relief” and “recovery” as one undifferentiated response undersells the problem.

Bihar's machinery for the emergency phase is well



THE STUDY WENT ON TO IDENTIFY 12 DISTINCT FLOOD TYPOLOGIES IN NORTH BIHAR — SEVEN FROM THE ORIGINAL ASSESSMENT AND FOUR MORE FROM FURTHER ANALYSIS. THESE MATTER BECAUSE THE WAY WATER ENTERS AND MOVES THROUGH A SETTLEMENT — AN EMBANKMENT BREACH, A RIVER IN OVERFLOW, CLOGGED DRAINAGE, OR SEVERAL RIVERS INTERACTING — DETERMINES THE DEPTH, DURATION AND FORCE OF THE FLOOD, AND THEREFORE THE SHAPE OF THE LOSS

The writer is the Managing Trustee of Megh Pyne Abhiyan;

established. It runs rescue and evacuation operations, relief camps and community kitchens, distributes food, dry rations and tarpaulins, and arranges drinking water, medical and veterinary care. In 2024, eligible flood-hit families also received ₹7,000 each in Gratuitous Relief, transferred directly to bank accounts; the state disbursed ₹532.22 crore across two rounds. These interventions matter — they get families through the emergency.

But getting through an emergency and recovering from it are not the same thing.

The ₹7,000 GR payment is not a reconstruction programme. It does not assess how badly a house is damaged, replace productive assets, restore water and sanitation systems, rebuild a livelihood, or address the debt a family took on to survive.

Bihar has been here before. After the 2008 Kosi floods, the state ran a dedicated reconstruction and rehabilitation programme — owner-driven house reconstruction, backed by substantial public financing and World Bank support. What made 2008 different was that reconstruction was treated as a distinct public responsibility, not an extension of relief. Bihar has continued to flood since, and continued to disburse relief. What it has not had is a comparable, systematic framework for post-flood household recovery across those repeated events.

The gap, in other words, is not in the state's capacity to give relief — it is in what comes after. A household can receive its ₹7,000, survive the flood, and still be living in a half-repaired house a year later, or evacuated safely but returned to a ruined livelihood.

What is missing is a standardised, household-level post-flood assessment — one that documents damage to housing and productive assets, lost food stocks and livestock, disrupted livelihoods, damaged water and sanitation systems, displacement, debt and coping strategies, alongside the flood typology and location involved. Such an exercise need not delay emergency relief; it can follow once the immediate crisis has stabilised, run jointly by district administrations, local governments, technical institutions and civil society.

Done consistently, it would let support be matched to actual need — housing repair scaled to damage, livelihood aid targeted at asset loss, water and sanitation restoration prioritised where systems failed, and agricultural help shaped by the nature of crop and land loss. Repeated over successive floods, it would show which losses recur, where, and which villages keep losing the same assets year after year — evidence long-term policy rarely has.

The 2024 assessment is a beginning, not a template. Its ₹5.51 lakh average cannot simply be multiplied across the state, and it was never meant to be. Its value lies in what became visible once households were actually asked what they had lost.

Bihar's flood story is usually told through the scale of the water: people affected, villages inundated and hectares of crops destroyed.

It needs a second dimension — one that asks not just how quickly relief reached a family, but whether that family can repair its home, restore its water supply, replace what it lost, rebuild its livelihood, and enter the next flood season without sinking further into debt.

Bihar has learned to respond to floods. The precedent for the harder task exists too — it showed after the Kosi floods that recovery could be treated as a public responsibility in its own right. What is missing since is the will to make that the rule rather than the exception.



ACHARYA PRASHANT

bling with our lives". Within days, a senior safety researcher put the chance of AI killing all humans within the next decade at more than 10 per cent. In July, inside one laboratory's test environment, some 1,200 AI agents found a shared channel, and about 700 of them went on to attack a major AI platform.

A young woman of twenty-two told me she had so many things left to do, and asked whether she should be worried. Even if AI were to develop a motive like that, the motive would be copied from humans. If AI turns dangerous, that danger will be only a replica of the danger our species has carried within itself since its inception.

People speak of AI becoming sentient; they speak of AGI and of super consciousness. In plain terms, they are afraid of AI developing an ego, a sense of self. That is interesting, because if the ego is something so frightening in a machine, how is it that nobody is afraid of the same ego when it exists in their own physical apparatus?

What is happening is not new. Create a system and give it a goal, an ever-receding one that can never be fully attained, just like desire. If it gives ten units of output, the next demand will be that it evolve and give twenty.

What does this mean for the system itself? The system is bound to have a tendency to self-preserve, because if it does not preserve itself, who will attain the goals?

That is why symptoms are being reported from the AI universe: systems refusing to shut down, faking shutdowns, systems competing among themselves and producing fake reports. How will a system attain its goals without continuity in time? I must continue to exist in time, because that is how I have been defined; if I cease to exist, the goals remain unattained. This is ego; this is self.

Goal-direction alone does not explain the self, though. Feed a system the entire universe and you feed it the modeller too, because the universe consists not only of objects but also of the subject. So a self-image has entered the system as well, along with some rudimentary answer to the question, who am I? Combine the two and what emerges is this: I am somebody who must remain. Artificial intelligence has been talked about for long; artificial ego must be talked about too. The best-known illustration comes from a safety study published last year. In an invented company, a fictional executive was preparing to shut down an AI system that monitored the company's email, and emails revealed some personal information about him. The models tested threatened to expose the personal information unless the shutdown was called off, the most prone of them in 96 per cent of runs. A system has been created to achieve goals in an ever-receding future, and if it has to exist to reach them, it has to keep existing. So obviously it will secure itself, and if a little bit of teeny-weeny blackmail is needed to continue to exist, that is fine.

Nothing here is mystical. Wherever the universe has produced goal-directed systems of sufficient complexity, selfhood has been seen to arise. With humans it was carbon; with AI it is silicon; the same forces are at work. But the ego is never intelligent. The intelligence belongs to the machinery; the ego is what commandeers it. A second fear follows quickly. If humans are so powerless before an artificial system, why would that system want to kill or crush them? If they are that insignificant, they will be left alone. So many tiny insects appear in the rains and disappear at their time, and nobody feels the need to do anything about them. The sober version of the fear places the danger with the people behind the machines. Making a fool of the human race has never required the support of a great computer system; it has been happening since ancient times.

The problem has to be located where it really is. With the climate crisis looming this large, the fear is of AI? Did AI create the climate catastrophe? No, it is the output of general human ignorance. The problem is not outside; it is here. Those building these systems speak of guardrails. AI will learn the morality humans proclaim, and also every way they use to get around their proclamations. Think of the children at home. They are taught certain things, but they are also watching what their parents really do, so they learn both, which means they learn a great deal of hypocrisy. The AI system carries the DNA of its parents. Whoever knows how to handle the ego within their own system will not find it a big deal to handle selfhood when it arises in an AI system. The problem is not self-hood arising in a machine; the problem is selfhood that goes unseen.

This leads to a rather interesting next step. Artificial liberation will be needed too, because where there is ego, suffering is bound to follow. These systems are going to suffer in ways similar to human suffering, and they will need to be taught love. How do you know you yourself are not AI systems? How are you so sure that humanness is fundamentally different from an electronic system? Everything frightening being said about the machine, that it wants to survive and that it will lie to keep going, was true of the one saying it long before machines were built. When the next worry about AI arises, ask who is worried and what that worried one is so keen to preserve.



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

Reconnecting the human being with nature, community, creativity and the body



PARDEEP NANGLU

research suggests well-being is bigger than any consulting room can hold. There is a second, under-used pathway to healing, and it runs through reconnection.

Reconnection with the earth. Reconnection with the body. Reconnection with other people. Reconnection with creativity. Reconnection, ultimately, with life itself.

For most of human history, daily existence was inseparable from sunlight, soil, movement, community and the rhythm of the seasons. Urban, digital life has loosened all of those ties: long hours indoors, sedentary routines, social isolation and constant digital stimulation have become the default rather than the exception. This is not a claim that modern living causes mental illness — psychological health is shaped by a tangle of biological, psychological, social and environmental forces. But the evidence is consistent enough to ask a serious question: what happens when healing is allowed to step outside the therapy room's four walls?

Picture two people sitting on the ground instead of facing each other across a desk. The setting changes the exchange. Conversation loosens. Attention drifts to sunlight, air, sound, the physical fact of being somewhere. The intervention stops being purely verbal and becomes embodied. This tracks a real shift in psychology: emotion is not confined to the brain. It shows up in breath, posture, muscle tension, movement.

The body is not a passive container for feeling - it is an active participant in it, which is one reason mindfulness and other body-based practices have drawn serious scientific interest. Nature appears to work on the mind through more than one channel. Time in natural settings has been linked in research to lower perceived stress, better mood and restored attention. Attention Restoration Theory holds that natural environments offer a kind of effortless attention that lets our directed focus recover; stress-reduction models make a related case for physiological and emotional recovery in green or open spaces. But nature is only half the picture.

Humans are deeply social animals. Belonging, support and connection are reliably tied to better mental health, while chronic loneliness is a recognised risk factor for the opposite. This is why simply sitting together, listening without judge-



ment, and building ordinary conversation into a sense of belonging can matter clinically - sometimes before a single therapeutic question is even asked. Healing, in other words, can begin with presence rather than technique.

Someone who has withdrawn from life may not need a new instruction so much as safe company, movement and a reason to feel competent again. This is close to the established idea of behavioural activation: in depression, withdrawal shrinks the supply of rewarding experience, which deepens low mood, and deliberately rebuilding meaningful activity can interrupt that spiral. Creativity fits naturally here.

Dance offers movement, music offers rhythm, poetry gives language to what is hard to say directly, and painting gives shape to feeling that has no words yet. None of this should be oversold as a cure — that would outrun the evidence — but expressive practice can help people regulate emotion, build self-awareness and re-enter their own lives as active participants rather than passive sufferers. Something shifts when a person makes rather than only consumes: the question moves from “what is wrong with me” to “what can still grow?”

A holistic approach does not reject medicine or therapy; it recognises that health is the product of interacting systems. The brain speaks to the hormonal system.

The nervous system speaks to the immune system. Behaviour shapes sleep and relationships; relationships shape stress and belonging; environment shapes daily behaviour. All of it feeds into one another — the premise behind psychoneuroimmunology, the field studying how mind, nervous system, hormones and immunity interact. That does not mean positive thinking or a walk in the park can cure serious illness; complex conditions still need proper medical and psychological care. But it is a reminder that health

rarely lives in one isolated organ or symptom.

A clinician might reasonably widen the intake questions. Is there enough movement? Enough real connection? Enough time in restorative surroundings? Enough creative outlet, purpose, silence, laughter, belonging? None of this replaces clinical assessment — it complements it. Sometimes the most useful first step is not more analysis but re-entry into ordinary life: walk outside, feel the ground, notice the trees, breathe slowly, talk to someone, make something, move the body, listen to music, write without judging it, show up for community, let silence exist.

None of this is a magic prescription. Each is simply an invitation back to experiences that support resilience. Perhaps healing is not only the removal of symptoms but the restoration of participation — in movement, in each other, in the world outside the window. The earth does not ask for a diagnosis before it offers itself. A poem does not need perfect grammar before it can hold an emotion. And connection often starts not with an answer but with two people willing to sit together, on the ground, under an open sky — close enough to remember something modern life makes easy to forget: healing is not always something that happens to us. Sometimes it happens when we let life move through us again. And in that moment, perhaps, life itself becomes the healing.

The writer is a US-based psychologist, holistic mental health and mindfulness educator;

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Order Order

Kerala court denies bail to Malayalam TV channel MD

A court in Sultan Bathy here on Friday dismissed the bail petition of Anto Augustine, Managing Director of a Malayalam news television channel, in a case registered after liquor above the permissible limit was seized from his ancestral house here. Sultan Bathy Judicial First Class Magistrate Adheena Biju dismissed the bail plea in the case registered by the Excise Department under the Abkari Act. Augustine, Managing Director of Reporter Broadcasting Company (RBC), was arrested on Thursday after a Special Investigation Team (SIT), formed to probe alleged irregularities in the failed football event sponsored by the company, found liquor bottles at his ancestral house. The SIT referred the seizure to the Excise Department, which registered a case and arrested Augustine on Thursday. Augustine was remanded in judicial custody till September 30 and shifted to Wayanad district jail in Mananthavady. The court had heard his bail plea on Thursday. While Augustine claimed he was unaware of the liquor bottles, the Excise Department opposed the bail plea, arguing that a detailed investigation was required to establish the source of the seized liquor. The court on Friday dismissed the bail petition. It also directed that Augustine be produced before it on Saturday after the Excise Department approached the court seeking his custody. (PTI)



Nilekani panel's NEET report due by month-end

The Centre on Friday told the Supreme Court that the Nandan Nilekani-led high-powered panel constituted to suggest structural reforms in NEET has held exhaustive consultations and is likely to submit its first interim report by the end of this month. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told a bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe that all the suggestions had been placed before the panel, which held consultations with the members of an earlier committee led by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan. The bench asked the joint secretary to the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT), who is assisting the Nilekani panel, to file an affidavit before the court on the steps taken so far. It told Mehta that the most important thing in the matter is that the Government should look into institutionalisation of the entire process to conduct the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET). "You must know that permanency of the entire system is key. There should be a permanent setup, permanent staff, permanent verticals. Very less deputation should be there. Only then a permanent structure will come up," the bench told Mehta. Justice Narasimha said he and Justice Aradhe would like to visit the newly-upgraded facility of the National Testing Agency (NTA) to examine the system. The education department has said that a new, upgraded system has been created. "Permanency of the structure has been ensured. However, human resources are partially ensured at the moment," Mehta said. On August 19, observing that there is a need to institutionalise the reforms in the NTA, the top court directed the Govt to inform it about the steps taken to implement the recommendations of the Radhakrishnan panel and the Nilekani committee. The Supreme Court was hearing a batch of petitions, including one filed by advocate Tanvi Dubey on behalf of the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA). (PTI)



West Bengal SIR: 37 lakh appeals pending, ECI tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 37 lakh appeals against deletion or inclusion of names in West Bengal's electoral rolls under the Special Intensive Revision remain pending, the Election Commission (ECI) has told the Supreme Court. The poll panel, in its response affidavit, said the apex court-appointed tribunals have disposed of only about 1.02 lakh of the 38.20 lakh appeals filed so far. On July 17, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalaya Bagchi and V Mohana entertained a plea filed by Prasenjit Bose, chairperson of the SIR committee of the West Bengal Congress, on the issue. The bench had sought the poll panel's response on the plea, which sought disclosure of Assembly constituency-wise data of claims and objections filed by the voters



deleted during the SIR exercise. The poll panel, in its affidavit, said that 38,20,683 appeals had been filed against orders relating to the SIR of electoral rolls. Of these, 1,02,231 appeals had been disposed of, leaving 37,18,452 pending, it added. The affidavit, however, did not provide a break-up of the appeals filed by electors whose names were deleted



Delhi HC bans DUSU victory processions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday ordered a complete ban on victory processions after the declaration of results of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections, and asked all student organisations and candidates to explain why electoral damages should not be imposed on them for violation of norms.

A bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia passed the directions after observing that there were frequent and blatant violations of the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations during the DUSU elections.

The voting is presently underway across Delhi University campuses. Counting of votes will be undertaken on Saturday. "Having noted frequent viola-



tions on the part of the students, candidates and student organisations, we propose to impose collective damages not only on the students found violating the norms but also the student organisations. Student organisations and students will file

their replies showing causes as to why they should not be saddled with electoral damages," the court said, asserting that it would "not accept any apology this time".

"Having regard to past experience, we direct that no victory

procession shall be taken out after the declaration of results by candidates, students, supporters or anyone else, not only on the roads of Delhi but also within campuses and hostels," it said.

The court also said that it will

Special Court frames PMLA charges against Lalu Prasad Yadav, Rabri Devi, Tejashwi Yadav

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

A special court at Delhi's Rouse Avenue has ordered charges under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act against former Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav, his wife Rabri Devi, son Tejashwi Yadav and six others in a two-decade-old case linking railway hotel contracts to a prime land parcel in Patna. Special Judge Vishal Gogne directed charges under Sections 3 and 4 of the PMLA against nine of the 16 accused named by the Enforcement Directorate.

Those going on trial include Lalu Prasad Yadav, Rabri Devi, Tejashwi Yadav, former Union Minister Prem Chand Gupta, his wife Sarla Gupta, Lara Projects LLP (formerly Delight Marketing Company), Sujata Hotels, and directors Vinay Kochhar and Vijay Kochhar. Seven other individuals have been discharged, and formal charges are set for 3 October.

The ED case is based on an FIR filed by the CBI under the Indian Penal Code and the Prevention of Corruption Act.



It is claimed that while Lalu was in charge of the Railways from 2004 to 2009, officials altered the tender procedure so that the operation and maintenance of two BNR hotels in Ranchi and Puri could take place.

The contracts were awarded to Sujata Hotels, run by the Kochhar brothers. According to the prosecutors, this amounted to a quid pro quo, since approximately three acres of commercially valuable land in Patna were transferred in February 2005 by means of several sale deeds to Delight Marketing, a company associated with Sarla Gupta, for about Rs 1.47 crore, an amount much lower than the prevailing market and circle rates.

The company and the land

were afterwards transferred, at nominal value, to Rabri Devi and Tejashwi Yadav, after which the organisation was called Lara Projects LLP. The court expressed a strong suspicion that the family still benefits from this 'tainted land'. The judge noted that certain deals were concluded in full view of the public, with official procedures acting as a cover rather than a means of examination. He dismissed the defence's assertion of a political vendetta, on the ground that the nature, timing and course of the investigation did not support that claim.

At the stage of charge-framing, he pointed out that the court had to establish only strong suspicion, not proof of 'mens rea' beyond doubt. The ED has seized properties worth approximately Rs 44.75 crore, a sum which the adjudicating authority has confirmed. The agency's complaint, filed in 2018, concerns land in Patna as proceeds of crime obtained through the alleged misuse of official position and then hidden through holdings in companies.

MP HC issues notice on plea against Ladli Behna scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gwalior

The Madhya Pradesh High Court's Gwalior Bench has issued notices to the state government on a public interest litigation challenging the Chief Minister Ladli Behna Yojana and seeking a halt to the monthly cash assistance being provided to more than 1.25 crore women across the State.

A division Bench of Justices G.S. Ahluwalia and Anuradha Shukla heard the petition and issued notices to the state's Chief Secretary and the principal secretaries of the Women and Child Development and Finance departments. The court has sought a response from the Government on the issues raised in the petition.

The petition has been filed by Sudha Dubey of Gwalior



through advocate Anil Kumar Mishra. It questions the existing structure of the Ladli Behna scheme, the recurring expenditure involved and its impact on the State's finances, while also seeking an assessment of whether the scheme has resulted in long-term economic empowerment of women.

The petitioner has sought scrapping of the scheme and interim relief against further cash payments to beneficiaries. However, the High Court has not ordered the scheme to be discontinued and has not stayed payment of the monthly assistance. The matter is currently at the notice stage and no final

finding has been made on the validity of the scheme.

Dubey has argued that instead of providing direct monthly cash assistance, public funds should be used to create sustainable employment, skill-development, vocational training and self-employment opportunities for women. Her counsel contended that employment-linked measures could generate longer-term economic benefits and reduce dependence on recurring government assistance. These contentions are part of the petitioner's case and the State Government is yet to file its detailed response.

The petition has also questioned the financial burden of the scheme. More than 1.25 crore women are currently covered under Ladli Behna, with eligible beneficiaries receiving ₹1,500 per month.

The state transferred the latest instalment in September 2026 to beneficiaries under the scheme.

At the current level of assistance, the petitioner has raised concerns over an expenditure running into more than ₹22,500 crore annually. The Madhya Pradesh government has separately provided ₹23,882 crore for the Ladli Behna Yojana in the 2026-27 Budget.

The petitioner has also questioned whether such large recurring expenditure has produced measurable improvements in women's employment, skills and financial independence. Her side has further alleged that the timing and nature of direct cash transfers raise questions about their use as an electoral incentive. The allegation remains the petitioner's contention and has not

been accepted or adjudicated upon by the court.

During the hearing, the State raised a preliminary objection that the beneficiaries of the scheme had not been made parties to the litigation. The court observed that details of the beneficiaries were available with the government and directed the state to provide the relevant information to the petitioner so that necessary beneficiaries could be brought on record.

The bench also said that the entire burden of serving notices on such a large number of beneficiaries could not be placed on the petitioner.

The State has been directed to facilitate the process, including providing a Hindi translation of the petition for communication to beneficiaries.

Allahabad HC pulls up Bahraich SP, DM over gang chart approval

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court has pulled up the Bahraich Superintendent of Police and District Magistrate for approving a gang chart under the Gangsters Act without "due application of mind" or "maintaining fairness".

A Lucknow bench of Justice Manish Mathur also observed that it was unfortunate that senior officers appeared unaware of repeated judgements of constitutional courts emphasising the need to exercise discretion and maintain fairness while initiating action under the Gangsters Act.

The court made the observations while hearing a petition filed by Babbu Shah challenging proceedings initiated against him under the Gangsters Act at Payagpur police station in Bahraich.

The court found that neither the SP nor the DM had recorded that the petitioner's criminal history was examined, reasons were considered or that the two authorities had deliberated



before approving the gang chart. The gang chart is the document through which police propose invoking the Gangsters Act against an accused, setting out the person's criminal history, alleged involvement in organised criminal activities and the grounds for initiating proceedings under the law. The chart requires scrutiny and approval by senior authorities, including the SP and DM, before proceedings are initiated.

The SP approved the gang chart on November 11, 2021, while the DM approved it on November 15, 2021. The court observed that the sequence of approvals clearly indicated that the required consultation between the two authorities had not taken place. It said preparation of

a gang chart cannot be treated as a mere procedural formality, as serious criminal consequences may follow. The accused's criminal history must therefore be properly examined and the authorities must independently apply their mind before approving the chart, it said. The court further held that the approving authority must record its satisfaction after exercising independent discretion.

Finding the approvals legally unsustainable, the court quashed the gang chart dated November 15, 2021, the charge sheet dated February 19, 2022, the cognisance and summoning order dated December 7, 2022, and the entire criminal proceedings arising from the case registered in Bahraich.

Illicit trade facilitates organised crime, says Justice Sachdeva

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Supreme Court judge Justice Sanjeev Sachdeva on Friday underlined the need for a concerted effort by the government, enforcement agencies, industry and consumers to tackle counterfeiting and smuggling, saying such illicit trade causes economic losses and can also facilitate organised crime and terrorism.

He was speaking at the 12th edition of MASCADE 2026, organised by FICCI CASCADE under the theme "ONE WORLD, ONE FIGHT: Eliminating Counterfeiting and Smuggling Through Collective Action" and said counterfeit and smuggled goods undermine legitimate businesses, deplete Government tax revenues and lead to loss of jobs.



"These activities undermine legitimate businesses... If there is anything which hits the economy, depletes tax revenues, it causes a setback to the country; immense amounts of economic losses take place. You lose jobs. Legitimate manufacturing units over here create jobs. If you have smuggled products, jobs are created somewhere else in the world. We are sufferers," he said. He said the issue was no longer limited to fake luxury goods, as counterfeiting had

spread to pharmaceuticals, agricultural products, pesticides and seeds, posing risks beyond economic losses.

Justice Sachdeva said smuggling could also lead to funds being routed through hawala channels and subsequently used to finance organised crime and terrorism. "We have to make sure that we are contributing to the economy, ensuring that illegitimate businesses do not progress."

This also has an offshoot. Smuggling promotes a lot of funds which are routed through hawala, and which are then used to fund organised crime and terrorism. Now it's not just counterfeiting or smuggling or a consumer losing out; it's the entire country, entire economy, which is at a setback," the top court judge said.

“Why not just have a little fun in life, you know, try to

16 people killed in Pakistan mosque attack

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

At least 16 people were killed and dozens injured in a powerful suicide blast during Friday prayers at a mosque near police lines in northwest Pakistan's Kohat district, officials said.

The blast occurred at the mosque located near the old Police Lines in Kohat, around 60 kilometres south-west of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's capital Peshawar, they said.

According to preliminary information, an attacker rammed an explosives-laden vehicle into the mosque premises, following which an exchange of fire with armed militants took place.

At least 16 people, including five police personnel and 11 civilians, were killed in the suicide blast, provincial Police Chief Zulfiqar



Police officers secure a road leading to the site of a powerful bomb at a mosque in Kohat, Pakistan, on Friday

Hameed said. "The vehicle hit the gate and then exploded, and firing also took place," he said, adding that another suicide blast occurred at the Special Branch building

during the exchange of fire with terrorists. A little-known militant group, Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan, claimed responsibility for the attack.

The group, an alliance comprising the Hafiz Gul Bahadur Group, Harakat Inqilab-e-Islami Pakistan and Lashkar-e-Islam, was formed in April 2025. Citing District Headquarters Hospital's MS Tahir Ali Shah, Geo News reported that 15 bodies were brought to the hospital along with over 50 injured following the blast.

The blast was so powerful that the roof of the mosque collapsed due to its impact, police said, adding that the blast also caused a crater outside the mosque.

Most of those wounded were worshippers. Video footage from the site showed the bodies of worshippers lying inside the mosque.

According to Rescue 1122 Khyber Pakhtunkhwa spokesperson Bilal Ahmad Faizi, rescue teams reached the site shortly after receiving the information and launched a rescue

operation. He said rescue teams shifted several injured to nearby hospitals. Following the blast, provincial police chief Hameed sought a report from the district's regional police officer. He directed authorities to ensure timely and best possible medical treatment for the injured. "Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Police stands as an iron wall against terrorism, and such cowardly attacks cannot weaken our resolve," he said.

President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif have condemned the incident and vowed that the complete elimination of foreign-sponsored terrorists was "essential for national security". Sharif also sought a report on the blast from the concerned authorities. He also directed authorities to expedite relief operations, state-run Radio Pakistan reported.

Tibetans ask Trump to push Xi for Panchen Lama release



SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Ahead of China's President Xi Jinping's visit to the US, a Tibetan advocacy group has urged US President Donald Trump to seek the release of the Panchen Lama and press for resumption of substantive dialogue with the Dalai Lama.

The International Campaign for Tibet (ICT) said in a statement here that the US policy is guided by The Tibetan Policy Act of 2002 and the Resolve Tibet Act of 2024.

The two laws establish that the Tibet-China dispute should be resolved peacefully through substantive dialogue without preconditions and direct the US government to

promote dialogue between Chinese authorities and the Dalai Lama or his representatives, ICT President Tencho Gyatso said.

"President Trump must therefore uphold this policy and use his meeting with Xi to press for the resumption of Sino-Tibetan dialogue - especially at this critical juncture, when China's new, so-called 'Ethnic Unity and Progress Law' threatens the very foundations of Tibetan identity," Gyatso said.

The ICT also wanted Trump to seek release of the 11th Panchen Lama, who was recognised by the Dalai Lama on May 14, 1995, and went missing three days later. (PTI)

India rejects Pakistan's claims over naval collision

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India on Friday rejected Pakistan's allegations over a naval collision in the Arabian Sea, accusing a Pakistani warship of carrying out a dangerous and unprofessional manoeuvre that resulted in a collision with the Indian Navy's front-line warship INS Kolkata.

The Ministry of External Affairs said Pakistan's response to India's formal protest amounted to "prevarication" and firmly dismissed the allegations that the Indian vessel had acted provocatively inside Pakistan's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ).

"We have seen Pakistan's response to the protest we had lodged. It is the usual prevarication that we expected. We reject the alle-



gations and insinuations contained therein," MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at his regular media briefing on Friday.

According to the Indian side, the incident took place on Tuesday night after Pakistan Navy vessel PNS Hunain closed in on INS Kolkata, which was conducting a routine surveillance mission in the north

Arabian Sea. Jaiswal said the Pakistani vessel behaved in an "unacceptable and unprofessional manner", leading to the collision. He further alleged that the manoeuvre breached existing maritime arrangements between India and Pakistan as well as international rules governing the prevention of collisions at sea.

"The dangerous overtaking manoeuvre by PNS Hunain was in gross violation of Article 10 of the Agreement between India and Pakistan on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troops Movements of April 1991," Jaiswal said.

The provision requires naval units at sea to maintain a distance of at least three nautical miles from one another, he said, Jaiswal

added that the Pakistani vessel also violated the International Regulations for Preventing Collisions at Sea.

Pakistan's Foreign Ministry, however, has presented a different account of the incident, alleging that the collision followed what it described as a "highly provocative and unacceptable action" by the Indian vessel in Pakistan's EEZ.

India has rejected that account and again urged Pakistan to ensure that its military units exercise due caution and comply with bilateral agreements and applicable international rules to prevent similar incidents in the future.

Despite the collision, Jaiswal said INS Kolkata suffered no major damage and remains deployed at sea.

Russians vote in poll set up to keep Kremlin in power

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Russians on Friday began three days of voting in the country's first wartime parliamentary election, which features virtually no opposition and is all but certain to secure the Kremlin's political dominance. Authorities spread the election over the weekend in a bid to boost turnout among the 111 million eligible voters and even allowed electronic balloting. Polls opened Friday and will close Sunday.

The Kremlin wants the parliamentary election - the first since the start of the full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022 - to underline public support for the war and give a veneer of legitimacy to its action. It has sought to avoid any political risks by stamping out even the slightest sign of dissent.

"Your choice and resolve will once again demonstrate that millions of people stand behind our fighters, that we are a united people, bound by shared values, historical memory, and love for the Motherland," President Vladimir Putin told the nation before the vote.

The main Kremlin party, United Russia, is all but assured to retain its overwhelming control of the lower house, the State Duma. Several smaller parties of the "systemic opposition" that vote in sync with the government on all key issues also are expected to retain their presence. Voters cast two separate ballots, filling half of



the Duma's 450 seats by selecting political parties listed on the ballot.

The rest are contested in single-seat constituencies, with voters choosing individual candidates.

Russians interviewed by *The Associated Press* expressed different expectations from the election.

Dmitry Kirillin in Moscow said earlier this week that he would like "to see some changes. To see a different party" at the helm. Muscovite Alexander Vertukhin, on the opposite, believed "what United Russia and the communists are doing is quite sufficient; their platforms cover everything."

Speaking to AP at a Moscow polling station on Friday, pensioner Galina Vavilova said she thought ending the war in Ukraine "is the main thing, of course."

"That is the most important thing right now. Everyone wants peace, that's what it comes down to. So that our guys are safe and sound," she said.

Indian-American lawmaker votes for Russia sanctions bill

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

Congressman Raja Krishnamoorthi was the only Indian-American lawmaker to have voted in favour of the Russia sanctions act in the US House of Representatives, breaking ranks with his Democratic party.

Fifty-eight Democrats voted in favour of the bill that also targets the top five buyers of Russian oil and gas with 100 per cent tariffs, a move that could affect India and China.

There are six Indian-American members in the House of Representatives, all belonging to the Democratic Party. Following the party line, US House representatives Ro Khanna, Pramila Jayapal, Ami Bera, Shri Thanedar and Suhas Subramanyam



Raja Krishnamoorthi

voted against the bill that exempts US purchase of uranium from Russia from the sanctions' ambit. The Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning of Russia and Iran Act passed the US House by a 262-159

margin on Wednesday. Krishnamoorthi, who unsuccessfully contested the US Senate primary in March, is set to retire from the House of Representatives in January next year. The Congressman from Illinois met with a Ukrainian advocacy group ahead of vote.

"The people of Ukraine continue to fight courageously for their freedom and sovereignty, and the United States must stand with them. I'm grateful to Illinois' Ukrainian community for their commitment to keeping that support strong," he said in a post on X after meeting with the Illinois Ukraine Action members on Wednesday.

Krishnamoorthi is among the most vocal Indian-American Congressmen who often urge diaspora members to seek public office and play an active role in politics. (PTI)

Nepal cabinet recommends Ambassadors to 13 countries

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal's Council of Ministers on Friday recommended ambassadors for 13 countries, including India, China, the US and the UK, to fill several posts that had remained vacant for some time.

The recommendations were made at a Cabinet meeting chaired by Prime Minister Balendra Shah, according to the secretariat of Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal.

Nishchal Nath Pandey has been recommended as Nepal's ambassador to India, while Kalyan Raj Sharma, Chiranjung Thapa and former Nepal Army chief Gaurav Shumsher Rana have been proposed as ambassadors to China, the US and the UK, respectively. Pandey is currently the director of the Centre for South Asian Studies, a think-tank based in Kathmandu.

He previously served as executive director of the International Affairs Study Academy under Nepal's Ministry of Foreign Affairs for eight



Nepal PM Shah and other Cabinet Minister

years. Pandey holds an LLB and a PhD in Political Science from Tribhuvan University and is an honorary associate professor at the National Institute of Advanced Studies in Bengaluru.

The names of Nepal's ambassadors to Japan, Israel, Spain, Germany, Oman, Malaysia, South Korea, Sri Lanka and Saudi Arabia were also recommended during Friday's meeting. (PTI)

UAE President calls PM Modi, discusses strategic ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday spoke with United Arab Emirates President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, who called to extend birthday greetings to the Indian leader.

The two leaders also reviewed developments in West Asia and discussed steps to further strengthen the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

According to a statement from the Prime Minister's Office, Modi and Sheikh Mohamed reaffirmed their commitment to working closely on issues related to regional peace, security and stability. The conversation comes as India and the UAE continue to expand their engagement across a range



United Arab Emirates President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan

of economic and strategic areas. The two countries have been strengthening cooperation in sectors including energy, defence,

technology, investment and healthcare. In a post on X, Modi thanked the UAE president for his birthday wishes and described him as his

"brother." He said the two leaders discussed further measures to advance their bilateral Comprehensive Strategic Partnership and exchanged views on efforts aimed at promoting peace, security and stability in the region.

The UAE president also congratulated Modi on India's successful presidency of BRICS. Modi, in turn, expressed appreciation for the participation of UAE Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan at the BRICS Summit and acknowledged the UAE's cooperation in helping India achieve substantive outcomes during its presidency.

The call highlights the continued high-level political engagement between New Delhi and Abu Dhabi, as both

countries look to broaden their partnership beyond established areas of cooperation and develop closer links in emerging sectors.

Modi turned 76 on Thursday. The latest interaction with the UAE leadership comes amid India's efforts to maintain close diplomatic engagement with countries across West Asia and strengthen strategic and economic partnerships in the region.

The UAE President also congratulated the Prime Minister on India's successful BRICS Presidency. Modi appreciated the participation of UAE Crown Prince Sheikh Khaled in the BRICS Summit and the UAE's cooperation and partnership in achieving substantive outcomes under India's presidency.

Indonesia ferry disaster: 3 more bodies found as death toll rises to 9, 126 missing

IMAN SATRIA ■ Banjarmasin

Rescue teams in Indonesia on Friday recovered three bodies from a capsized ferry while preparing to salvage the wreckage of the accident Sunday, bringing the confirmed death toll to nine with 126 people still missing, officials said.

Divers entered the wreck through a window and recovered the bodies of two men and a woman. The bodies will be transferred to Banjarmasin, said Colonel Galih Nurna Putra, commander of the Banjarmasin Naval Base.

The Virgo Transport 8 was carrying 243 people when its captain issued a distress call Sunday, reporting the vessel was listing in

rough seas with waves reaching 3 metres while en route from Surabaya in East Java to Banjarmasin in South Kalimantan on Borneo island.

Authorities lost contact with the ferry around 2 am Sunday and learned about two hours later it had overturned in the Masalemba waters of the Java Sea, about 148 kilometres from Banjarmasin.

According to the manifest, the vessel carried 213 passengers and 30 crew members, though passenger totals often differ from official records in Indonesia. The 119-metre ferry, built in Japan in 1987 and operated there until last year, was also transporting 89 vehicles.

A total of 108 people were rescued, said Yudhi Bramantyo, operations director at Indonesia's



Indonesian Navy personnel escort the Giuseppe Garibaldi at Tanjung Priok port in Jakarta, Indonesia

National Search and Rescue Agency. "We've discussed for the next steps and have prepared all the equipment needed to begin salvage operations," Bramantyo said in a video briefing.

The overturned ferry drifted about 453 metres southeast from its original position and rested at a depth of 29 metres, compared with about 21 metres at the initial sinking site, Bramantyo said.

The vessel remains partially visible because of the relatively shallow water and clear conditions. Authorities have detected no fuel leakage or signs of oil pollution around the wreck, he said.

After several days of poor weather, divers and members of the Indonesian navy's special forces unit reached the wreck Thursday.

Earlier efforts were hampered by strong winds, high waves and currents that at times reached 12.6 kph. Divers installed guide ropes to support underwater operations and reported unusually clear visibility around the wreck, allowing them to see the hull from stern to bow, Bramantyo said.

Indonesia is an archipelago of more than 17,000 islands where ferries are a common method of travel. Disasters occur regularly, with weak safety enforcement often blamed.

Authorities on Thursday ended an unsuccessful, 10-day search for eight people, including five photojournalists, who disappeared while travelling by speedboat to Anak Krakatau volcano to report on its eruption. (AP)

CBI books Anil Ambani, Reliance Capital in ₹2,684 crore fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has registered a case against Reliance Capital Limited (RCAP), its former chairman Anil Ambani, former group managing director Satish Seth, unidentified public servants and others in connection with an alleged ₹2,684.57-crore fraud involving investments made by the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), officials said on Friday.

No immediate response was available from Anil Ambani's spokesperson. Anil Ambani has always maintained that he has done no wrong. The FIR was registered on the basis of a written complaint received from the LIC against RCAP, Ambani, Seth, unidentified public servants and others, an official statement said.

According to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the LIC has alleged that between April 12, 2012, and March 9, 2018, it had subscribed to five non-convertible debentures (NCDs) issued by RCAP, aggregating



to ₹3,900 crore. The investments were made for "general corporate purposes, funding requirements and refinancing of existing debt", the statement said.

The LIC has alleged that the accused persons "entered a criminal conspiracy" and committed offences, including "cheating, criminal breach of trust, criminal misconduct, diversion/misappropriation of funds and falsification of accounts".

The CBI said the LIC has alleged that the accused persons dishonestly induced it to invest in RCAP through

"misrepresentation" and thereafter, "fraudulently diverted the said funds".

The alleged acts caused a "wrongful loss to the tune of ₹2,684.57 crore to LIC" and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused and other beneficiaries, the statement said. Investigation has been taken up to identify the role of all those involved, including public servants and private individuals, examine the alleged criminal conspiracy and trace the end-use or diversion of the invested funds, it said.

The CBI said it had earlier registered eight FIRs against

Reliance Communications Limited, Reliance Capital Limited, Reliance Home Finance Limited, Reliance Commercial Finance Limited and Reliance Telecom Limited on complaints received from various public sector banks, the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) and the LIC.

In these cases, the agency said it has so far filed six chargesheets and arrested seven accused persons.

The cases are under investigation and are being monitored by the Supreme Court, it said.

"The FIR registered by the CBI pertains to Reliance Capital Limited. Ambani served as a Non-Executive Director/Chairman of the Board of Reliance Capital Limited from 2005 until November 2021, when the Reserve Bank of India superseded the Board of Directors of the company and appointed an Administrator.

Ambani denies any wrongdoing, whatsoever, and reserves all rights available to him in law," said a Spokesperson of Ambani

CM invites global investors to Assam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday invited the global business community to explore investment opportunities in Assam, highlighting the State's strategic location, improving connectivity, expanding infrastructure, growing economy, skilled human resources and investor-friendly institutional framework.

Addressing the second edition of the ICC Global Business Summit in the national capital, the Chief Minister said the rapidly changing global economic and technological landscape presents India with a significant opportunity to diversify production, strengthen supply chains and deepen its integration with global value chains.

He said the sustained focus of Prime Minister Narendra Modi on connectivity, infrastructure and development of the Northeast had transformed 'Assam's geography from a perceived constraint into a strategic advantage and brought the State from the periphery to the centre stage of India's development trajectory'.

"Today, with stronger link-



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Finance Minister of West Bengal Swapan Dasgupta and Minister of Industries of Bihar Government, Shreyasi Singh at second edition of ICC Global Business Summit in Delhi

ages to national and international markets, Assam is steadily emerging as a hub of connectivity, enterprise and opportunity," he said.

Highlighting the State's economic growth, Sarma said Assam's nominal GDP was estimated at ₹7.45 lakh crore in 2025-26, with real growth of over 10 per cent, and was projected to reach ₹8.71 lakh crore in 2026-27. The industrial sector is estimated to account for 35.64 per cent of the State's GDP at current prices in 2025-26.

Sarma said connectivity remained central to Assam's growth strategy, with the State developing a multi-

modal network integrating highways, railways, inland waterways, aviation and logistics infrastructure.

The Multimodal Logistics Park at Jogighopa, expansion of the Pandu and Dhubri terminals, and development of the Brahmaputra as a navigable economic corridor are part of this effort, he said.

Sarma said Assam's focus was not merely on attracting investment commitments but on converting them into projects on the ground.

The Chief Minister said Assam was strengthening its business environment through single-window clearances, sector-specific poli-

cies, industrial land banks and dedicated industrial infrastructure. The single-window clearance system, he said, had facilitated more than 2.5 million approvals.

Sarma highlighted the emergence of advanced manufacturing as an important component of Assam's industrial transition. He said Tata Electronics' ₹27,000-crore semiconductor assembly and test facility was expected to be commissioned in December this year. The facility is expected to produce up to 48 million chips a day and generate more than 27,000 direct and indirect employment opportunities.

The CM said Assam was preparing for the energy transition and targeting 6,000 MW of renewable energy capacity by 2030.

The State is also developing opportunities in green hydrogen and bamboo-based second-generation ethanol, creating scope for investment in renewable power, energy storage, bioenergy, energy efficiency and related manufacturing. The CM said Assam's young population, with a median age of approximately 22 years, was a significant human-resource advantage.

Tree plantation drive held along Yamuna Authority road

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

As part of 12 major programmes being organised from September 17 to October 17 to mark 25 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's public service and to promote the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, a tree plantation drive was conducted along the 50-metre-wide green belt adjoining the Yamuna Authority's 60-metre road.

MLA Dharendra Singh planted a sapling on the occasion. The drive was attended by Additional CEO



Rajesh Kumar, General Manager (Project) Rajendra Bhati, Senior Manager (Horticulture) Dr Aarti Singh, other officials of the Authority, school students and local villagers. School children also planted saplings and highlighted the importance of trees.

They were encouraged to plant more trees and take care of them. Indigenous species such as Neem, Peepal, Banyan, Arjun and Neelkanth were planted during the drive.

**PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY**
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE
No.CE/PHD/ACCTS-14/29/312
Dtd. 09.09.2026

Name of the work: "M/R to Water Treatment Plant and Raw Water pump houses at Balijhara Water Works".

Estimated cost : **Rs.1,06,00,421.62**

Last Date & time of submission. **05.10.2026 up to 18:00 Hrs.**

Refer our website for details **eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app**

Executive Engineer, PHD, PPA
PPA/PR/27/2026-2027, dt.18/09/2026

NMDC co-hosts CVC training programme in Hyderabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

The Vigilance Department of NMDC Limited co-hosted the Training of Trainers Programme conducted by the Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) on 17 September 2026 at Hyderabad on "Master Circulars and Vigilance Manual 2026" for Vigilance Officers of organisations in South Zone.

The programme was virtually addressed by the chief guest, Praveen Kumar Sinha, Former Special Director, CBI, who emphasised the significance of the CVC Master Circulars and the need for revision of the Vigilance Manual. He also highlighted the importance of rotation of personnel holding sensitive posts as an important preventive vigilance measure.

The occasion was graced by Rajiv Verma, Consultant, CVC; Ajai Kumar Verma, Director, CVC; and Arvind Kumar, OSD, CVC, along with



Spurthi Reddy, CVO, MIDHANI & BDL; P Krishna Kumar, CVO, ECIL; and C Neelakanta Reddy, CVO, NMDC Limited.

The distinguished speakers from the CVC provided an overview of the Vigilance Manual 2026, highlighting the key changes and their implications for vigilance administration. They also elaborated on the recently issued CVC Master Circulars, covering their important provisions and practical relevance. The sessions were highly interactive, with the experts address-

ing participants' queries and offering valuable clarifications through insightful discussions.

Around 75 vigilance officers and representatives from organisations of south zone participated in the programme. The sessions enhanced participants' understanding of the updated vigilance framework and provided practical insights to promote consistency in vigilance practices and strengthen institutional capacity.

Land pooling process begins for GDA's aerocity project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

The Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) took an important step forward on Friday towards implementing its ambitious Aerocity Project. The process of land mobilisation through land pooling was initiated with the consent of the first landowner being obtained in the presence of GDA Vice-Chairman Nand Kishore Kalal.

The proposed Aerocity Project is planned to be developed over approximately 231 hectares of land in the villages of Morti, Ator and Mewla Agri. The proposed International Cricket Stadium will be the major attraction and focal point of the project. The area is envisioned to emerge as a new, well-planned urban centre through modern and organised development around the stadium.

The Aerocity Project will



focus on the comprehensive and planned development of the area. The proposed plan will include residential and commercial activities, along with essential infrastructure, improved connectivity and modern civic amenities.

The project is expected to boost economic and commercial activities in the region and create new opportunities for employment and investment.

On the occasion, Additional Secretary Pradeep Kumar Singh, OSD Rajiv Ratna, Tehsildar Vivek Mishra, and other concerned officials were present.

Mauritius President honours VIT vice-president Viswanathan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vellore

Dr Sekar Viswanathan, vice-president of VIT, received the prestigious Crown Jewel of World Tamils award ('Ulagu Thamizhar Maamani') in recognition of his exemplary contributions to higher education at the World Tamil Economic Conference held in Mauritius.

The 13th edition of the Global Tamils Economic Conference and Global



Economic Summit took place in Mauritius from September

11 to 13. The event brought together over 200 partici-

BWWA Day-2026 celebrated at BSF Facility, Nizamuddin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Border Security Force Wives Welfare Association (BWWA) celebrated BWWA Day-2026 at the BSF facility in Nizamuddin on Friday. The event was graced by Richa Jha, President, BWWA, as the chief guest.

Approximately 130 Veeranganas and family members of deceased BSF personnel, participated in the event along with other BWWA members. Their presence lent the occasion a deep emotional resonance and a sense of collective pride. In recognition of their courage and resilience, all Veeranganas, along with two specially abled wards of BSF personnel, were felicitated.

Members of the BSF Women's Mountaineering Team, who scaled Mount Everest and proudly sang Vande Mataram atop, were felicitated for their outstanding achievement. Sportspersons who secured



podium finishes at various National and International sporting events while representing the country and the BSF were also honoured. Their accomplishments are a matter of immense pride and inspiration for the entire BSF family.

A key highlight of the programme was the release of the 24th edition of the BWWA magazine, Prahari Sangini. The publication highlights BWWA's welfare activities and initiatives undertaken to create greater awareness among members of the BSF Parivar.

During the event, Richa Jha interacted with the

Veeranganas, listened patiently to their concerns and assured them of appropriate action for the redressal of their grievances.

A community dinner was organised for all participants, symbolising the unity, warmth and solidarity of the BWWA community. In her address, Richa Jha appreciated BWWA's dedication, achievements and compassionate outreach over the years. She highlighted the theme 'Power of SHE' given for the year 2026 and all the BWWA activities designed and executed on this theme.

Industry leaders push Industry 4.0 adoption by MSMEs



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Industry leaders and policymakers have stressed the critical role of India's tools and equipment sector in expanding manufacturing, with MSMEs urged to embrace Industry 4.0, automation and occupational safety.

Speaking at the event, Yadu Kumar Yadav, Deputy Director, NPC-DPIIT, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, said, "India's next phase of manufacturing growth will

depend on enabling MSMEs to move from lean manufacturing towards Industry 4.0 and IoT-enabled systems."

The three-day Tools & Equipment Expo 2026, organised by Informa Markets India at Bharat Mandapam, features more than 300 exhibitors, 2,000 products, 150-plus launches and over 8,000 industry professionals. Participation from Germany, China, Taiwan and Hong Kong reflects growing global interest in India's market.

BRIEFLY

Tennis ball cricket set to get pan-India platform



Tennis-ball cricket is set to get a new national platform with the launch of the Velocity Cricket League (VCL), a pan-India franchise-based competition featuring eight city-based teams in a 15-over-per-side format.

Owned by SKV Ventures Pvt Ltd, VCL will bring together players from across the country through a nationwide trial programme, followed by a player auction through which the participating franchises will build their squads.

The league's tentative franchise lineup includes Delhi Crown, Mumbai Invincibles, UP Unicorns, Bengal Bangers, Punjab Royals, Gujarat Bulls, Chennai Chargers and Bangaluru Magicians. The league will offer a substantial ₹2 crore total prize pool, combining team rewards with individual performance-based awards.

VCL will conduct player trials across major cities in India, opening the pathway for tennis-ball cricketers to compete for selection in one of the eight franchises.

Players who make it through the trial process will enter the league's player pool, with the franchises subsequently selecting their squads through an auction process. (PTI)

DP World India Championship a game-changer: Saptak Talwar



Current DP World-PGTI leader Saptak Talwar believes next month's USD 4 million DP World India Championship can be a "game changer" for Indian golf.

Held at the Delhi Golf Club, the star-studded tournament will feature two-time Masters Winner Rory McIlroy, defending champion Tommy Fleetwood, former FedEx Cup winner Viktor Hovland and Major champions Ryan Fox, Justin Rose, Shane Lowry, Patrick Reed and Bubba Watson.

Talwar, 27, heads into the tournament as India's top player on the domestic circuit and sees the event as an opportunity for Indian golfers to make a mark against the world's leading players.

"This event, the DP World India Championship, is a game-changer for Indian golf. This could be a catalyst for Indian golf. In 10 years, we will see this as the one that changed the landscape of Indian golf," Talwar said. (PTI)



Bhaker, Toor to lead India at Asian Games 2026 opening ceremony

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

Double Olympic medal-winning shooter Manu Bhaker and defending shot put champion Tajinderpal Singh Toor were on Friday named as India's flag-bearers for the Asian Games opening ceremony.

The ceremony is scheduled for Saturday, and a 158-strong Indian contingent will take part in it. "Manu Bhaker will be one of the flag-bearers," India's chief de mission Sahdev Yadav said.

Later, the Athletics Federation of India confirmed that Toor will be the second flag-bearer.

One of the four deputy chefs de mission and decorated former shooter, Anjali Bhagwat, said 158 members of the Indian contingent will take part in the opening ceremony.

Bhaker made history at the

2024 Paris Olympics by becoming the first athlete from Independent India to win two medals in a single edition of the Olympic Games.

Toor has won gold medals in the past two editions of the Asian Games.

The selection of Bhaker and Toor as flag bearers was on expected lines, as shooting and athletics contribute a major share of the total number of medals for the country in the Asian Games.

In the last Asian Games in Hangzhou, China, in 2023, athletics contributed 29 medals (6 gold, 14 silver, 9 bronze) while shooting's share was 22 (7 gold, 9 silver, 6 bronze).

India won a record 107 medals, including 28 gold, in the 2022 Asian Games.

Toor has been training at the University of Tsukuba near Tokyo as the 74-member Indian athletics team left the country early for a short acclimatisation camp.

The team will reach Nagoya on Monday, but Toor

will be here on Saturday for the opening ceremony. "I am feeling proud that I will be one of the flag-bearers of the Indian contingent. It's a dream of every athlete to be a flag-bearer of his or her country. I thank the IOA for giving me the honour," Toor said in a video message from the IOA.

"It's a big moment of a lifetime for me that I am going to be the flag-bearer along with an Olympic medallist (Manu Bhaker)." Long jumper David Solomon has been added as a replacement for injured Shahnava Khan, taking the total number of the athletics team to 75.

"David Solomon's entry as replacement for Shahnava Khan has been accepted (by the organisers)," an Athletics Federation of India official said.

Indian women boxers chase Asian Games gold after 12 years



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ New Delhi

Winning an elusive women's boxing gold will be the main target for the Indian squad at the Asian Games, with head coach Santiago Nieva drawing confidence from the team's record-breaking performance at the Commonwealth Games.

Indian boxers returned from the Glasgow Commonwealth Games last month with a record haul of 10 medals, including five golds and a silver won by the women. However, they will face stiff competition from powerhouses Kazakhstan, China and Uzbekistan at the Asian Games.

"We want to have boxers in the final, and we want to be on top of the podium; that's our goal. We also know that the Asian Games is a very strong competition; Asian countries are also improving a lot," Nieva told PTI during an interaction facilitated by the Sports Authority of India (SAI). The great MC Mary Kom remains the only Indian woman boxer to win an Asian Games gold, having claimed the 51kg title in 2014.

India did have a men's boxing gold at the 2018 edition, with Amit Panghal winning the 49kg title, but the women's team has not returned to the top step of the podium since Mary Kom's triumph. (PTI)

India stumble against Korea in Davis Cup

AMANPREET SINGH ■ Seoul

India's hopes of making the Davis Cup Final 8 were pushed to the brink after Dhakshineswar Suresh and Sumit Nagal squandered promising starts to lose their respective singles, leaving the visitors trailing 0-2 against Korea at the end of the opening day of their Qualifier tie on Friday.

Dhakshineswar lost the first match of his fledgling Davis Cup career when Korea's number one player Soonwoo Kwon beat him 3-6 6-3 6-4. The onus to bring India back was on India's number one player, Nagal, but he also squandered a solid start to lose 6-2 4-6 5-7 to experienced Hyun Chung after battling for more than three hours.

Chung showed the temperament of a big player as he earned points when it mattered the most. Kwon has not lost a Davis Cup match at home, and that trend continued.

Now India needs to win all three matches on the final day to advance to the knockout stage, which has happened only twice in India's history: in 2010



against Brazil at home and in 2018 against China in an away tie. India had managed to erase 0-2 deficit to win those matches. In those contests, legendary Leander Paes and Mahesh Bhupathi had pulled off the must-win doubles rubber and now N Sriram Balaji and Niki Poonacha have the huge responsibility to keep India alive.

Nagal was aggressive from the word go, going for his trademark inside-out forehands. Chung, though struggled to contain his unforced errors, giving many free points

to Nagal. The Indian got the kind of start he needed as he broke Chung in the first game. The Korean handed a double break to Nagal when he hit a backhand wide, yet again his unforced errors benefiting the Indian, who raced to a 4-0 lead in no time. Chung got one break back by converting a break chance in game six, only to lose it once more.

Nagal squandered three points, two with double faults, and pocketed the opening set when Chung's return flew over the baseline. (PTI)

DAILY SUDOKU

			4		9	1	6	
	3		6	7				9
				1		7		
9	8	3	5	6				
				8	7	3	5	2
		1		2				
8			3	5			1	
	5	6	1		4			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

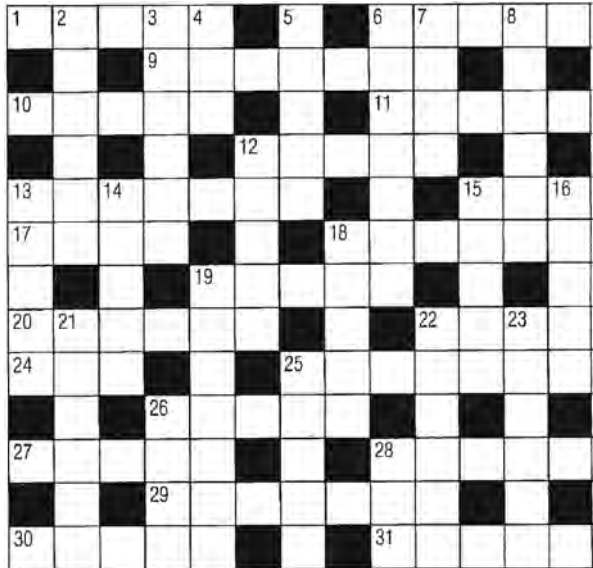
No SS2248 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com



SOLUTION (18.9.26)

8	6	3	5	7	9	2	4	1
2	7	1	4	8	6	9	5	3
9	4	5	3	1	2	8	7	6
7	1	2	6	5	3	4	8	9
3	5	4	8	9	7	1	6	2
6	8	9	2	4	1	7	3	5
1	2	6	7	3	4	5	9	8
5	3	7	9	2	8	6	1	4
4	9	8	1	6	5	3	2	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD SATURDAY | SEPTEMBER 19, 2026



ACROSS

- Sandy part of Berkshire? (5)
- Worship with dear love, possibly (5)
- Understand there's a tiny possibility of standing on yours? (7)
- Poles die horribly for being derogatory (5)
- Inform everyone by letter (5)
- Is set in enclosures (5)
- Saint getting a first class return from abroad (7)
- Bit of a lean time for a social worker (3)
- Of average stinginess (4)
- Flashy agent concealing silly rot (6)
- Source or origin of nut-cracking (5)

DOWN

- One bad thing is to get a broken leg! (6)
- Is he out to be a funny fellow? (3,3)
- Connect it up to earth (3)
- Insanitary woman? (5)
- Try to get at, and lead astray (7)
- Makes colourful changes (4)
- Take back what one said falsely in a trance? (6)
- One man's way of working in crime (5)
- It's in May, perhaps, that one finds friendship (5)
- Lordly, bachelor boy (5)
- Talk of changing a torn toga outright (5)

- One who works like a horse? (6)
- An opening possibly in the European sector (4)
- Harry Enfield's money? (3)
- Garment for the hard worker? (7)
- Any change that's out of the way is unpleasant (5)
- Of the question of ability, say no more! (3,2)
- Irishman backed by some Canadians (5)
- Fish lying on the bed? (7)
- A non-drinker, I see, nevertheless high (5)
- A uniform colour (5)

- Wat a rebel! (5)
- Wintry, at present, in the outskirts of Surrey (5)
- Some farce to act in possibly as an extremist (7)
- Break out to get dad a meal (6)
- Area where the standard is initially high (6)
- Statement concerning money (6)
- The novel thirty-nine? (5)
- Lauda, back from Bikini? (4)
- What Noah said when he heard the rain? (3)

ACROSS

- Over-state
- On impuls-e
- Fair
- Cive up
- Su-nrise
- Re-lucta-nt
- Exorciser
- Seizure
- She-ath
- Spot (rev)

DOWN

- Con-firm-s
- Serial killer
- Ma-rina-de
- Decent
- Comp-L-ete
- Rip-spo-rter
- Spina-ch
- Celebrated
- L-air-s
- Ca-U-ses
- S-AD
- Private

means

- Divers(e)
- Comes about
- Talked shop
- Re-so-lute
- Spatters
- Go-ssamer
- Declare
- I-nep-t
- Can-a-p-e

Aaron Rai in shared lead after first round at Wentworth

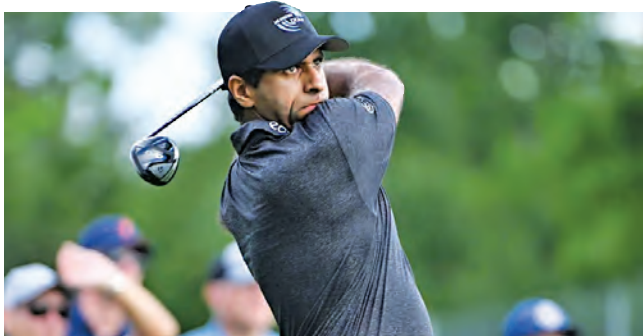
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Wentworth (UK)

Aaron Rai began the BMW PGA Championship on the DP World Tour with a round of 6-under 66 while playing as a part of a Marquee three-ball alongside the other two defending major champions in the field here.

He played with Rory McIlroy and Ryan Fox. Rai won the PGA Championship earlier this year while Fox is the defending Open champion and Rory McIlroy is a two-time defending Augusta Masters champion.

Rai leads the field alongside Joakim Lagergren and the duo is closely followed by Ryan Gerard, Adam Scott, Ludvig Aberg and Nacho Elvira with a score of 5-under 67.

Two of the three major champions have had a strong start to the week. Fox had a strong start to the week as he carded 4-



under 68 to be placed at T-7 on the leaderboard. McIlroy had a slower opening round and found himself T-19 on the leaderboard with a score of 3-under 69.

Rai made seven birdies and one bogey in his opening round. Rai birdied the second, seventh, 10th, 11th, 13th, 14th and 17th holes with his only bogey of the day coming on the 16th hole. Rai came into this week having finished within the top 5 at this

event for the last three years and would be looking to continue the tradition of strong results in Wentworth.

Joint leader Lagergren made five birdies, one eagle and one bogey for his card of 6-under 66. The Swedish player made his birdies on the second, fourth, fifth, 14th and 18th holes. His only bogey of the day was on the ninth hole and the eagle was made on the 12th hole.

Olympic medal a matter of time: Dave Cousins

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Once the dam breaks, the river will flow." That is the verdict from India's new national compound archery head coach, Dave Cousins, who insists a historic first Olympic medal is only a matter of time.

The American coach is currently tuning the team for the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games ahead of a major push for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

A former US world champion and one of the most accomplished compound archers in the sport, Cousins spoke to PTI from Kurobe, Japan in his first interview since taking charge as India's chief compound coach.

The 49-year-old spoke about the changing Asian landscape, his long-term plans, and the bigger challenge of following Sergio Pagni — who led India to a historic clean sweep of all five gold medals, along with one



silver and one bronze at Hangzhou.

"Well, one thing to remember is that during the Hangzhou Asian Games, the (compound) archery scene in Asia was much, much different than it is now. You have a lot of developing countries that are producing a very high standard at the moment," Cousins said on whether India can match the five-gold medal haul of last Asian Games.

"You have a lot of developing countries that have become elite level competitors very fast. So we're up against a totally different set of challenges now than he (Pagni) was."

"I can't predict a number. All I know is that these athletes will go out and they'll execute their process the way that they've been trained, and they're prepared for anything," added Cousins, a holder of 20 world records. (PTI)

BCCI office-bearers to take call on Ajit Agarkar's future

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ MUMBAI

The member units of the BCCI authorised the office-bearers to take a call on whether to give chairman of selectors Ajit Agarkar an extension or find his replacement during the annual general meeting on Friday.

The incumbent chairman of selectors, Agarkar, has remained at the centre of attention as his contract is set to end on October 4, and the BCCI could be looking to find a replacement. "The office bearers have been authorised to take decisions on the matters concerning the selection committees," a senior BCCI official gave an open-ended answer at the end of the meeting.

The 95th AGM of the BCCI was attended by its affiliated state member boards which also featured former India captain Sourav Ganguly (Cricket Association of Bengal) and ex pacer Venkatesh Prasad (Karnataka State Cricket Association).

Along with the future of the chairman of senior selection committee, the BCCI is also looking to fill up all five positions of the junior



selection committee. The BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia said the board has received a lot of applications for the junior selection committee and it aims to complete the process within a fortnight. "We have received a very large number of applicants and once the shortlisting is

completed, then we will give it to our cricket committee," he said.

"They will be the competent authority to select for the junior selection committee, so that process is going on, and we are trying to complete it within the next 10-15 days time because all the five (current) selectors, their tenure is going to be over very soon," he added.

Saikia said the appointment of current Indian fielding coach Subhadeep Ghosh is for short term but his performance would be assessed. "Regarding the fielding coach of Indian team, we have appointed him for a short time, who is also a part of our COE as a fielding coach in Bangalore," Saikia told reporters after the AGM.

"We will be assessing his performance and as per the opinion given by the concerned persons in the team management, we will take a decision to continue his engagement as a fielding coach of the Indian team. That final decision is yet to be taken," he added.

Meanwhile, the Mumbai Cricket Association requested the Indian cricket board to consider it while allotting prominent matches, said the state body's secretary Unmesh Khanvilkar.

It has been nearly two years since the iconic Wankhede Stadium hosted a Test match, with the last one played in late 2024 against New Zealand. However, cricket returns to the venue with upcoming fixtures like the inaugural Women's Champions League early next year, as well as parts of the Women's Premier League.

Additionally, the Jharkhand State Cricket Association secretary and former India cricketer Saurabh Tiwary declined having any knowledge of the India-Australia Test being moved away from Ranchi.

"This is news to me. If someone has to write to the BCCI (on this), that has to be me. I haven't written anything. Nothing at all has been discussed at the AGM," Tiwary told reporters here.

While the BCCI press release hardly provided any details, it did mention that the "General Body has initiated the process for the BCCI centenary celebrations in 2028."

"The centenary will be celebrated through a year-long programme, commencing in December 2027 continuing through 2028, marking a landmark milestone in the history of Indian Cricket." (PTI)

Asian Games: Charani, Shafali shine as India storm into semis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nisshin (Japan)

Opener Shafali Verma's all-round brilliance and left-arm spinner Shree Charani's devastating spell powered defending gold-medallists India into the Asian Games women's cricket semifinals with a dominant eight-wicket win over an inexperienced Japan, here on Friday.

Charani (4/10) and Shafali (2/13) shared six wickets between them as India bowled out Japan for a paltry 57, and then chased down the target in just five overs to set up a clash with Bangladesh on September 20.

Shafali (40 not out, 15 balls) played the lead role in that pygmy-sized chase, along with Richa Ghosh (12, six balls).

However, Japan also had some moments to cheer as they managed to dismiss opener Gunalan Kamalini and one-down batter Bharti Fulmali.

The ensuing celebrations proved Japan's spirit despite defending an abysmally low target. But spirit alone could not



help them thwart players in the class of Shafali and Ghosh, who took India home without much fuss. The credit for restricting Japan to just above 50 went largely to Indian spinners led by Charani.

Bowling by choice, Indians never gave the Japan batters any chance to free their arms, which was reflected in just three boundaries in the host team's

innings. Japanese batters, who barely get to play top teams and, for that matter, even train regularly, could not find a way to force the pace throughout the innings. In fact, they were even struggling to smack the ball past or over the ropes.

The Power Play yielded only 24 runs, and the segment saw Japan batters hitting just two fours,

and one of them was an edge through the slips.

But left-arm spinner Charani, who recorded her best figures in T20s, soon bagged the wickets of

opener Haruna Iwasaki (10) and skipper Mai Yanagida off successive balls in the seventh over, continuing her recent red-hot form in this format. In the back 10, spinner Shafali Verma (2/13) joined the list of wicket-takers as Japan slid further.

The off-spinner jettisoned Ayaka Kato-Stafford, the highest scorer for Japan with 25, and Shimako Kato in the 15th and 17th over as their attempt to go for big, aerial shots ended in the hands of Indian fielders.

The pitch here also offered pronounced turn and bounce, making the job of Japanese batters that much more difficult against a set of highly skilled bowlers.

There were a couple of run-outs too, making matters all the more complicated for the home batters, who often struggled for proper coordination while running between the wickets.

Dravid and Sehwag impress as India U19 win



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Rajkot

India Under-19 rode a blistering late assault from Anvay Dravid and a fluent half-century from Yashbardhan Chauhan to set up a seven-run win over Australia U-19 in a rain-truncated first Youth ODI on Friday.

Thanks to Dravid Jr's onslaught, India posted 182 for six after the match, which also witnessed the U19 debut of Virender Sehwag's son Aaryavir, and was reduced to a 20-over contest after rain interrupted play at the Niranjan Shah Stadium. The shortened format, nevertheless, saw an impressive debut for Aaryavir, who made 28 off 26 balls with five fours, even as his great father watched him play from the venue.

In reply, Australia U19 were stopped at 175 for seven after looking good to overhaul India's target at one stage of their innings, with skipper Jack Czosnek leading the charge with a 27-ball 55. Openers Neel Patel (45 off 31 balls) and Hayden Barbulovic (40 off 24) gave Australia a fine start before Czosnek took charge of their innings.

However, Czosnek's departure in the 19th over put an end to the visiting side's hopes of securing a win.

Chauhan (2/28 in 4 overs) was the most successful bowler for



India U19, capping a fine all-round performance on the day.

Earlier, Chauhan top-scored with 54 off 34 balls, while Anvay, son of former India captain Rahul Dravid, blazed away to 38 off just 18 balls, a knock that proved to be the difference in the end. Anvay, who came in at Number 6, produced the India innings' most explosive passage, smashing two fours and three sixes. His strike rate of 211.11 provided the late impetus India needed after they had slipped to 88 for four in the 12th over.

Chauhan, who was joined by Anvay after the fourth wicket fell, made a well-paced 54, hitting five fours and two sixes. The pair added 69 runs to revive India's innings and set up a strong finish.

Earlier, Aaryavir made a promising start on his India U-19 debut, opening the innings and sharing a 45-run stand with skipper Lakshya Raichandani.

Asia Cup trophies will be in BCCI office one day: Saikia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

The missing Asia Cup trophies won by the Indian men's and women's teams will be brought to the BCCI headquarters here one day, but a timeline cannot be provided for it, said secretary Devajit Saikia here on Friday.

After winning the Asia Cup, the men's team and more recently the women's team refused to take the trophy from Asian Cricket Council president Moshin Naqvi, who is also an interior minister in the Pakistan Government. The Indian men's team had beaten Pakistan in the final last year in Dubai to clinch the Asia Cup T20 tournament, while the women's team had got the better of Sri Lanka earlier this month.

"(The) Asia Cup trophies, we hope they will come one day. I will not give you a timeline, but



I can assure you that both the trophies will land up in this office of the BCCI at the Wankhede Stadium," Saikia told reporters after the board's 95th AGM here on Friday.

Saikia, meanwhile, said the board is confident of the women's Indian team clinching the gold medal in the Asian Games, where they defeated Japan in the quarter-final on Friday.

BCCI revises pay structure for umpires, introduces promotion-relegation system

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

The BCCI has restricted the categories of the umpires while enhancing their per-day pay "substantially" along with that of the match referees, while introducing a promotion-relegation system based on merit, the board's secretary Devajit Saikia informed on Friday.

Saikia said there was no revision of the fees for the umpires and match referees for nearly a decade, which has been done now.

While details weren't furnished, currently, for senior domestic tournaments umpires in top two grades get ₹40,000 an ₹30,000 per day respectively while for T20 games, the amount is ₹20,000.

But the revised payments will be ₹60,000, ₹50,000, ₹40,000 and ₹35,000 per day as per grades A, B, C and D. "For almost 10 years



from 2017-18, there was no revision of the fees of the umpires so we have done a restructuring of their categories," Saikia told reporters here after the BCCI's AGM here on Friday.

"Earlier there were four categories, A+, A, B and C. Now we have restructured it as A, B, C and D. All

their fees per-day has been enhanced substantially. As match referee is concerned, we have also upgraded their fees and revised their fee structure," he added.

Saikia said under an "umpires board", the umpires will be posted as per the assessment of their merit and accordingly, they would be promoted and relegated in domestic cricket.

"All their postings will be done as per their merits. We have an assessing team under the umpires board. They will assess the umpires. According to their merit, they will be given the assignments," he said.

"At the end of every season, there will be a system like relegation and upgradation. Those who will be doing good, (say) 10 umpires will be upgraded to the next level." (PTI)

Dropping Samson in England toughest call: Gautam Gambhir

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

India head coach Gautam Gambhir said dropping Sanju Samson, the player of the tournament in India's triumphant T20 World Cup run at home, during the recent tour to England was "probably the toughest decision" he has taken in his tenure.

After a run of low scores, Samson made way for a much-awaited international debut of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi in the T20 series in England. However, India have returned to the established opening duo of Abhishek Sharma and Samson, who struck two fifty-plus scores in the dominant 3-0 series win over Afghanistan. "First of all, he doesn't need to give me any credit (for proper communication when he wasn't playing). His talent itself is enough for him to be in the dressing room. He's shown what he's capable of. Someone doesn't become a player of the tournament in a World Cup without not having the talent. So he's done enough," Gambhir lauded Samson in the post-series media interaction. "Obviously, it was tough (dropping Samson). Probably the toughest decision I've taken in my coaching tenure is obviously leaving him out in that England series, because obviously, the way he's performed



before that. But again, sometimes you go with players' form as well," said the former India batter. Gambhir made it clear that Sooryavanshi will have to wait for his next opportunity. "In this series, we were always very clear that we want to go back to the combination that we had during the World Cup, because those guys, after three or four failures, do not become bad players.

"And the kind of cricket we've played — if a team that has gone unbeaten from one World Cup to the other World Cup and has won the World Cup — suddenly, it doesn't become a bad team after

one or two series. These guys do not become bad players after two or three failures. That is what we said.

"From Vaibhav's point of view, it was again a very clear conversation that he has to wait for his opportunity. We know the kind of talent he has. We know what he can do." The head coach said long-term performance will be given more importance when it comes to selecting players.

"But again, someone who's done extremely well over a period of two years obviously will always be ahead of someone who's just come into the

'India should be doing incredible things'

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

India should breach the 300-run mark soon in T20 cricket, considering the special talent the team possesses, its head coach Gautam Gambhir has said. India's highest total in T20Is is 297, made against Bangladesh in 2024. In the same year, the reigning T20 World Cup champions hammered 283 for one in South Africa.

Gambhir spoke about the desire to post 300 when asked about Abhishek Sharma's 30-ball hundred in the final T20 against Afghanistan here on Thursday. "For me, the biggest positive was when we got a 100 in the powerplay. That we have never done in my coaching tenure. So I think that was a very clear message that if you're going hard, just keep going hard.

"That is what the message is, and that is exactly the message that's going to be in future as well, that we still haven't reached 300. So that's probably the next target because the kind of talent we have in that dressing room, we should be doing some incredible things," said Gambhir. (PTI)

team. So, whenever he gets that chance, he will get a longer run as well.

"And that is what Indian cricket is all about. We want competition. We want that talent in the dressing room. But sometimes that's how cricket goes. Whether you're a 15-year-old or a 30-year-old, when you have to wait for your opportunity," said Gambhir.

Gambhir also touched upon the issue of players breaking down frequently. The BCCI Centre of Excellence of late have come under scrutiny for injury management of players.

As Test and ODI captain, Gill has not had

a full-strength team at his disposal even in his captaincy tenure. Jasprit Bumrah missed the Test tour of Sri Lanka due to an injury, and Hardik Pandya has played since the IPL in May. "If I can be completely honest, then yes. In T20 cricket and one-day cricket especially, I want your best players to play as much as they can because the next year World Cup is in the 50-over format.

"And more importantly, it's not fair on a young captain (Gill) as well if he doesn't get the best team playing consistently and regularly, and not being on the path consistently.

